

The Périgord Tapes

A private podcast series · Dordogne, September 12-18, 2026

Written to accompany “Périgord v13” — the itinerary where everything is booked, three gates are hard, and everything else flexes.

How to use this file (do not feed this section to the TTS)

What this is. Seventeen episodes plus an epilogue, written as spoken-word scripts for text-to-speech. Four long episodes set the backbone: a three-part regional overview for the flight over, and one long audio tour for the TGV from Paris Montparnasse to Bordeaux Saint-Jean. Then thirteen short warm-up episodes, one per site, in the exact order you’ll hit them, each sized to the drive or the walk-up right before you go in.

TTS rules for this document:

1. **Feed only the prose under each “SCRIPT” marker.** Everything in headings, tables, blockquotes, and bullet lists is production apparatus — episode notes, pronunciation references, timing — and is not meant to be heard.
2. **Paragraph breaks are breaths.** The scripts are paragraphed by breath group: a blank line means a full pause, roughly 700-900 ms. Within sentences, em dashes mark short lifts and commas quick ticks — most engines render both naturally. If your engine supports SSML, convert each blank line between paragraphs to `<break time="800ms"/>`. No inline tags appear in the script bodies themselves, because many engines read them aloud.
3. **French words appear with phonetic respellings woven into the sentences** the first time they matter in an episode (“Sarlat — say it sar-LAH”). After first mention, the plain spelling is used; most TTS engines do acceptably on repetition once the listener has heard the respelling. If your engine mangles a specific word badly, do a find-and-replace using the respelling column in that episode’s pronunciation table.
4. **Respelling convention:** hyphenated syllables, STRESSED syllable in capitals, “zh” for the French j sound, “ny” for gn, and nasal vowels approximated as “on,” “an,” “en” — a TTS engine reads these naturally and a human ear lands close enough that a French waiter will understand you.
5. **Numbers and money are written out as words** in the script bodies so the TTS never says “euro sign twelve point nine zero.”
6. Each episode ends with a **pronunciation table (IPA + respelling)** for your reference. Do not feed the tables to the TTS.
7. **Voice direction:** a single warm narrator, mid-register, conversational but unhurried — target roughly 145-155 words per minute (set 0.95× if your engine runs fast). Drop to about 0.9× with lower energy for Episodes 12 and 16, the two cave episodes. Give episode openers and closers an extra beat of silence.

8. **Test the engine before batch-generating.** The eight most-repeated names are respelled only at first mention per episode and appear bare afterward: Dordogne, Vézère, Sarlat, Les Eyzies, Lascaux, Font-de-Gaume, Beynac, Saint-Émilion. Generate one test paragraph containing each; if the engine mangles a bare repeat, find-and-replace that plain spelling with its respelling column throughout the affected episodes.
9. **Keep the connectives.** Respellings are introduced with a spoken lead-in (“pronounced,” “say it”) so the doubled name sounds deliberate rather than like a stutter. If you edit, preserve those lead-ins.

A note on privacy: no reservation numbers, card digits, or booking references appear in any script body — those live in your itinerary doc, and this is an audio file that might play out loud.

Itinerary review (do not feed to TTS)

You asked for a review of the driving times and the overall shape. Short version: **the plan is sound, the drive times are honest, and the sequencing is smart.** Details:

Drive-time audit — every leg checked:

Leg	Your allowance	Realistic	Verdict
Bordeaux → Saint-Cyprien (Sun 07:25→09:50)	2h25	~2h10-2h20 via Libourne/Bergerac	✓ Comfortable
Saint-Cyprien → La Roque-Gageac	25 min	~25 min	✓
La Roque-Gageac → Marquessac → Beynac	~10 min each	8-10 min each	✓
Beynac → Domme	20 min	~20 min	✓
Domme → Sarlat	25 min	~20 min	✓ Slack
Sarlat → Les Eyzies (Mon)	25 min	25-30 min — the D47 is twisty	⚠ Only slightly optimistic leg in the plan; your 15-min museum buffer absorbs it
Les Eyzies → Lascaux IV	35-45 min	~30-35 min	✓ Conservative, correctly so — this is the leg protecting the 12:50 gate
Lascaux IV → La Roque Saint-Christophe	25 min	~18-20 min	✓
La Roque St-Christophe → Essendiéras	55 min	~55 min	✓
Essendiéras → Les Eyzies (Tue)	60 min	~60 min	✓
Essendiéras → Saint-Émilion (Thu)	2h	~1h50-2h05	✓

Leg	Your allowance	Realistic	Verdict
Saint-Émilion → Bordeaux	45 min	40-50 min depending on rocade traffic at 15:30	✓

Shape notes:

- The **replica-before-original sequencing** (Lascaux IV Monday, Font-de-Gaume Tuesday) is the right order and Episode 2 leans into it: Monday gives you clarity, Tuesday gives you presence.
- **Museum before Lascaux** on Monday is the right call given the self-guided format, and the scripts treat the museum as the decoder ring for everything after it.
- One honest quibble: **Domme at 18:15 is lovely evening light, but it is not golden hour**. Sunset on September 13 is around 20:04; true golden hour starts ~19:15. You'll get warm low light on the valley, which is plenty — but if you ever want the real thing, it costs you your 20:00 dinner. The Domme episode says linger if you're tempted; the itinerary's trade is the right one.
- **Monday is the densest day** — museum, bakery lunch, Lascaux, La Roque Saint-Christophe, 55-minute transfer. Your doc already knows La Roque Saint-Christophe is the release valve. Agreed, and the script for it is written to work even if you arrive tired.
- Thursday's Saint-Émilion stop is a **narrative bookend** you may not have noticed you built: the Hundred Years' War that you'll watch across the river at Beynac on Sunday *ends* at Castillon, ten kilometers from Saint-Émilion, in 1453. Episode 17 closes that loop.
- Mid-September specifics are woven throughout: cèpe season (not truffle season — the scripts are honest about this), walnut harvest beginning, grape harvest likely underway around Saint-Émilion, morning mist on the Vézère, and the post-rentrée crowd dip that makes your timed slots less frantic than August.

Episode index (do not feed to TTS)

#	Episode	Listen when	Approx. length
1	A Valley Written in Limestone	On the plane, part 1	~30 min
2	The Painted World	On the plane, part 2	~30 min
3	Duck Fat and Gunpowder	On the plane, part 3	~30 min
4	The Backbone: Paris to Bordeaux by TGV	On the train, Sat 12	~45 min
5	Saint-Cyprien Market	Sun, driving in from Bordeaux	~5 min
6	La Roque-Gageac	Sun, leaving the market	~5 min
7	The Hanging Gardens of Marqueyssac	Sun, after lunch	~5 min
8	Beynac, the Angry Castle	Sun, the ten-minute hop	~4 min
9	Domme in the Evening Light	Sun, driving up the hill	~4 min

#	Episode	Listen when	Approx. length
10	Sarlat Before It Wakes	Mon, over coffee	~5 min
11	The Decoder Ring: Musée national de Préhistoire	Mon, driving to Les Eyzies	~5 min
12	Lascaux IV	Mon, driving to Montignac	~6 min
13	The Vertical City: La Roque Saint-Christophe	Mon, after Lascaux	~4 min
14	Essendiéras, Proust, and the Green Périgord	Mon evening or Wed morning	~4 min
15	Laugerie-Basse and the Grand Roc (optional)	Tue early, if you take the option	~4 min
16	Font-de-Gaume	Tue, the walk-up	~6 min
17	Saint-Émilion, Where the War Ended	Thu, on the A89	~6 min
18	Epilogue: Returning the Car at Number Thirteen	Thu, entering Bordeaux	~2 min

Master pronunciation reference (do not feed to TTS)

The complete list. Per-episode tables repeat the relevant subset.

French	IPA	TTS respelling
Dordogne	/dɔʁ̥.dɔŋ/	dor-DON-yuh
Périgord	/pe.ʁi.gɔʁ̥/	pay-ree-GOR
Périgord Noir	/pe.ʁi.gɔʁ̥ nwaʁ̥/	pay-ree-GOR NWAR
Vézère	/ve.zɛʁ̥/	vay-ZAIR
Sarlat-la-Canéda	/saʁ̥.la la ka.ne.da/	sar-LAH lah kah-nay-DAH
Les Eyzies	/le.z_ε.zi/	layz-ay-ZEE
Lascaux	/las.ko/	lass-KOH
Font-de-Gaume	/fɔ̃ də gom/	fon-duh-GOHM
Combarelles	/kɔ̃.ba.ʁɛl/	kom-bah-REL
Beynac	/be.nak/	bay-NACK
Castelnaud	/kas.tɛl.no/	kass-tel-NOH
Marqueyssac	/maʁ̥.ke.sak/	mar-kay-SACK
La Roque-Gageac	/la ʁɔk ga.ʒak/	lah ROCK gah-ZHACK
Domme	/dɔm/	DOM
Montignac	/mɔ̃.ti.nak/	mon-teen-YACK
Saint-Cyprien	/sɛ̃ si.pʁi.ɛ̃/	san see-pree-AN
Saint-Émilion	/sɛ̃.t_e.mi.ljɔ̃/	san-tay-mee-LYON
Essendiéras	/ɛ.sɔ̃.dje.ʁas/	eh-sahn-dyay-RAHSS
Excideuil	/ɛk.si.dœj/	ek-see-DOY
Hautefort	/ot.fɔʁ̥/	oat-FOR

French	IPA	TTS respelling
Montparnasse	/mɔ̃.paʁ.nas/	mon-par-NAHSS
Gare Saint-Jean	/gaʁ sɛ̃ ʒɑ̃/	GAR san-ZHAHN
Bordeaux	/bɔʁ.do/	bor-DOH
Garonne	/ga.ʁɔn/	gah-RON
Gironde	/ʒi.ʁɔ̃d/	zhee-ROND
Aquitaine	/a.ki.tɛn/	ah-kee-TEN
Aliénor (Eleanor)	/a.lje.nɔʁ/	ah-lyay-NOR
Périgueux	/pe.ʁi.gø/	pay-ree-GUH
bastide	/bas.tid/	bass-TEED
gabarre	/ga.baʁ/	gah-BAR
abri	/a.bʁi/	ah-BREE
Cro-Magnon	/kʁo.ma.ɲɔ̃/	kro-man-YON
Le Moustier	/lə mus.tje/	luh moo-STYAY
Moustérien (Mousterian)	/mus.te.ʁjɛ̃/	moo-stay-RYAN
La Madeleine	/la mad.lɛn/	lah mad-LEN
Magdalénien (Magdalenian)	/mag.da.le.njɛ̃/	mag-dah-lay-NYAN
La Gravette	/la gʁa.vɛt/	lah grah-VET
La Ferrassie	/la fɛ.ʁa.si/	lah fair-ah-SEE
La Micoque	/la mi.kɔk/	lah mee-KOCK
Laugerie-Basse	/loʒ.ʁi bas/	lozh-REE BAHSS
Grand Roc	/gʁɑ̃ ʁɔk/	grahn-ROCK
Abbé Breuil	/a.be bʁœj/	ah-BAY BROY
Peyrony	/pe.ʁɔ̃.ni/	pay-ro-NEE
Marcel Ravidat	/maʁ.sɛl ʁa.vi.da/	mar-SELL rah-vee-DAH
Étienne de La Boétie	/e.tjɛn də la bo.e.si/	ay-TYEN duh lah bo-ay-SEE
Montaigne	/mɔ̃.tɛɲ/	mon-TEN-yuh
confit	/kɔ̃.fi/	kon-FEE
magret	/ma.gʁɛ/	mah-GRAY
foie gras	/fwa gʁa/	fwah-GRAH
cèpe	/sɛp/	SEP
noix	/nwa/	NWAH
Cabécou	/ka.be.ku/	kah-bay-KOO
Monbazillac	/mɔ̃.ba.zi.jak/	mon-bah-zee-YACK
Bergerac	/bɛʁ.ʒə.ʁak/	bair-zuh-RACK

French	IPA	TTS respelling
vin de noix	/vɛ̃ də nwa/	van-duh-NWAH
pommes sarladaises	/pɔ̃m saʁ.la.dɛz/	POM sar-lah-DEZ
gariguet	/ga.ʁi.ɡɛt/	gah-ree-GET
chabichou	/ʃa.bi.ʃu/	shah-bee-SHOO
cannelé	/kan.le/	kah-nuh-LAY
jurade	/ʒy.ʁad/	zhoo-RAHD
tertre	/tɛʁtʁ/	TAIR-truh
Castillon	/kas.ti.jɔ̃/	kass-tee-YON
chevauchée	/ʃə.vo.ʃe/	shuh-voh-SHAY
bonjour	/bɔ̃.ʒuʁ/	bon-ZHOOR
s'il vous plaît	/sil vu plɛ/	seel-voo-PLUH
merci beaucoup	/mɛʁ.si bo.ku/	mair-SEE boh-KOO

Episode 1 — A Valley Written in Limestone

Listen on the plane. Part one of three. Approx. 30 minutes.

Production note: this is the geology and deep-time episode — why the caves exist, why the Vézère valley became the best address in Ice Age Europe, and who was living there for the last four hundred thousand years. Feed everything below the SCRIPT marker to the TTS, stopping at the pronunciation table.

SCRIPT

Welcome aboard.

Somewhere below you, the Atlantic is sliding past at five hundred miles an hour, and at the far end of this flight there's a wedding waiting for you at a château surrounded by apple orchards. But between you and that wedding, you two have booked yourselves into something much stranger and much older than a party. You are going to the Vézère valley — say it vay-ZAIR — a modest green river valley in southwest France that happens to contain the densest concentration of prehistoric art anywhere on Earth. Fifteen sites in that one valley are inscribed by UNESCO as a single World Heritage listing. Twenty-five decorated caves. More than a hundred and fifty ancient dwelling sites. And on Monday and Tuesday, you're going to stand inside two of the most important rooms our species has ever made.

So this is episode one of three for the flight. Consider it the deep foundation. Episode two is about the paintings themselves — Lascaux, Font-de-Gaume, and the question of why art exists at all. Episode three jumps forward and does the castles, the wars, and, crucially, the duck fat. But this episode goes down to bedrock, because one idea makes the whole Dordogne make sense, and it's worth carrying all week:

Everything you will see — every cave painting, every cliff castle, every honey-colored village, every vineyard — exists because of one rock. Limestone. The entire trip is one long conversation between water and limestone, running for about a hundred million years. Once you see that, the whole region snaps into focus.

Start with names, because the region has two and they're both on every sign you'll pass. Dordogne — pronounced dor-DON-yuh — is the modern administrative department, named for its biggest river. Périgord — pronounced pay-ree-GOR — is the old province, the name from before the French Revolution, and it's the name locals actually feel. It comes from the Petrocorii — pet-ro-KOR-ee — the Gaulish tribe who lived there when the Romans arrived — the name means something like “the four clans.” When a menu says Périgord, it's making a promise about tradition. And the Périgord comes in four marketing-friendly colors: green in the north, where you'll be for the wedding, all pasture and oak. White in the middle, for the limestone around Périgueux. Purple in the southwest, for the wine country around Bergerac. And black — Périgord Noir — in the southeast, supposedly for its dark oak forests, and that's where almost your entire itinerary lives: Sarlat, the river castles, and both painted caves.

Now let's make the limestone.

Wind the clock back roughly a hundred million years, to the Cretaceous. There is no France. There is no Atlantic as you know it — the ocean you're flying over right now is a narrow young rift still unzipping. Most of what will become southwest France is under a warm, shallow, tropical sea, on the shelf of a basin geologists call the Aquitaine Basin. And that sea is full of the tiniest architecture imaginable: coccolithophores — say it kok-oh-LITH-oh-fors — single-celled plankton that armor themselves in microscopic plates of calcium carbonate — plus shellfish, sea urchins, sponges, the whole quiet economy of a sunlit sea.

When each of those organisms dies, its little carbonate skeleton snows down to the seafloor. A slow, constant, invisible snowfall of chalk, millimeters per century. Do that for tens of millions of years and you get beds of limestone hundreds of meters thick. So when you put your palm flat on the cliff face at La Roque Saint-Christophe on Monday afternoon — and you should — you are touching the compacted bodies of trillions of creatures that lived and died in a sea that no longer exists, before *Tyrannosaurus rex* ever evolved. The cliffs of the Dordogne are made of accumulated lives. If one of you goes quiet and stares at a rock wall at some point this week, this is what they're thinking about. Give them a minute.

Then the sea leaves. Africa begins its long, slow shove into Europe, the collision that's still going on today — it raised the Pyrenees to the south and the Alps to the east, and it gently flexed and lifted the whole Aquitaine platform out of the water — gently enough that the Périgord was never crumpled into mountains, which is exactly why it's so good at being what it is: a broad, slightly tilted layer cake of limestone, raised just high enough for rivers to get to work on it.

And now water enters the story, in the two roles it will play all week: sculptor, and chemist.

The sculptor part is easy to picture. Rivers draining off the Massif Central — the old volcanic highlands to the east — flow west across the tilted platform toward the Atlantic. The Dordogne. The Vézère. Over a few million years they saw down through the limestone like a wire through cheese, but slowly, and with wandering hesitation. That's why both rivers meander in those huge lazy loops you'll drive along on Sunday. And every time the land rose a little more, or an ice age dropped the sea level, the rivers cut deeper, leaving their old floodplains stranded as terraces on the valley sides. Result: sheer golden cliffs, sometimes eighty, a hundred, a hundred and fifty meters of exposed Cretaceous limestone, standing above a green river. That is the postcard you'll be driving through on Sunday morning. Now you know what it is: a cross-section of a vanished sea, cut by a patient river.

The chemist part is subtler, and it's what makes the caves. Rainwater is not pure water. As it falls, and especially as it soaks through soil, it picks up carbon dioxide and becomes a very weak acid — carbonic acid. Limestone is calcium carbonate, and calcium carbonate dissolves in acid. Slowly. Molecule by molecule. So every drop of rain that lands on the Périgord for tens of millions of years does a tiny bit of quiet chemistry on its way down through the cracks. Cracks widen into fissures. Fissures into conduits. Conduits into

galleries. Where the water table sits, whole horizontal cave systems dissolve out of the rock like tunnels bored by a ghost. Geologists call this kind of dissolved, holey, secret-plumbing landscape karst.

And then — this is the beautiful two-step — the rivers cut the valleys deeper, the water table drops with them, and those flooded galleries drain out and are left high and dry in the cliff faces, empty and dark. A cave like Font-de-Gaume — pronounced fon-duh-GOHM — is essentially a fossil drain. The water that made it moved on hundreds of thousands of years ago, and what's left is a dry stone corridor into the hill, at a convenient height above the valley floor, with a stable temperature of about fourteen degrees Celsius year-round. Remember that number when you're shivering in there on Tuesday — you're feeling the average annual temperature of the Périgord, held in stone, because rock that thick doesn't notice seasons. It's the same reason the wine cellars in Saint-Émilion work, by the way. Same rock, same physics, different cargo.

One more piece of geology, because it explains Monday afternoon: the rock shelter. The French word is *abri* — ah-BREE — and you'll see it on signs all week. The limestone layer cake isn't uniform; some beds are harder, some softer. Where a river once ran against a cliff, or where frost gets into a softer bed — water freezing in the pores, expanding nine percent, popping grains off the face, thousands of winters in a row — the soft layer retreats and the hard layer above it holds, and you get a deep natural overhang: a stone awning, sometimes hundreds of meters long, open to the light and air but roofed against rain and snow. La Roque Saint-Christophe — say it lah ROCK san-kree-STOFF — which you'll walk on Monday, is a full kilometer of these shelves stacked eighty meters high. Laugerie-Basse, your Tuesday warm-up option, is another. Keep the distinction in mind, because it organizes everything this week: people lived in the rock shelters and painted in the caves. Episode two picks that thread up.

The stage is built: limestone, cliffs, caves, shelters, rivers. Now let's talk about why this particular valley became, for something like twenty thousand years, arguably the best place on the planet to be a human being.

Picture the Vézère valley at the coldest depths of the last Ice Age, around twenty thousand years ago. Northern Europe is under an ice sheet kilometers thick — Scandinavia, most of Britain, gone, white. But the ice never reaches the Périgord. Southwest France sits in a sheltered pocket — far enough south, close enough to the Atlantic's moderating breath, tucked in the lee of the Massif Central. Biologists call places like this refugia: pockets where life holds on while the world around them freezes. The climate resembles present-day northern Scandinavia: hard, but livable. There are no forests to speak of; it's open steppe-tundra, grasses and dwarf willow and juniper, endless and treeless.

And across that steppe move the animals. This is the part that's hard to picture from an airplane seat, so I'll try. The valley you will drive through on Monday — the quiet one with the walnut orchards and the canoe-rental signs — sat on one of the great migration corridors of Ice Age Europe. Reindeer in herds of thousands, moving between winter and summer pastures, funneled by the river valleys, crossing at predictable fords, twice a year,

every year, like a tide made of meat and hide and antler. Horses. Bison. Aurochs — wild cattle six feet at the shoulder; remember the name, because they're the stars of Lascaux's ceiling. Ibex on the cliffs. Woolly mammoth and woolly rhinoceros in the cold snaps. Salmon running up the rivers in numbers we'd now call impossible. One French prehistorian described Ice Age Périgord as a cold Serengeti, which still undersells the fish.

Now add the real estate. The south-facing rock shelters — and notice, when you're at La Roque Saint-Christophe, that the great occupied cliffs mostly do face south — are natural solar collectors. The cliff face soaks up low winter sun all day and radiates it back into the shelter through the evening. A shelter with a fire, a hide windbreak, and eighty meters of stone at your back is a warm, dry, defensible home with a commanding view of the river ford where the reindeer cross. Fresh water below. Flint — beautiful, glassy, knappable flint — weathering out of the limestone all around you, some of the best toolmaking stone in Europe, free for the picking.

Food, water, fuel, stone, shelter, warmth, sightlines. The Vézère valley was rich by any standard its age offered. And when a place is rich enough that you don't spend every waking hour on calories, interesting things start happening in the evenings. Surplus buys time, and time buys culture — which is one of the serious leading explanations for why this valley, of all places, filled up with art. More on that in episode two.

First, we need to meet the residents. Because one number is worth sitting with: the Vézère valley has been continuously significant to humans for at least four hundred thousand years. Your week there is a rounding error on the lease.

The earliest tenants we know well are the Neanderthals, and their ancestors before them. And I want to spend a minute rehabilitating them, because the valley you're visiting is one of the places that taught science to stop sneering. At a site called La Micoque — pronounced lah mee-KOCK — a few minutes from where you'll park in Les Eyzies, stone tools go back somewhere around three to four hundred thousand years. At Le Moustier — pronounced luh moo-STYAY — directly below the cliff of La Roque Saint-Christophe, which you'll drive right past on Monday afternoon, archaeologists found such a distinctive Neanderthal toolkit that the entire global culture is named for the hamlet: the Mousterian. When a textbook in Tokyo or Nairobi describes Neanderthal technology, it uses the name of a village you'll pass on your way to dinner. This happens over and over in the Périgord — La Madeleine, La Gravette, La Ferrassie — tiny local places whose names became the chapter headings of human prehistory, because this is where the type sites are: the reference digs against which finds everywhere else on earth get compared.

And the Neanderthals of these sites were not the grunting cavemen of the old cartoons. They made elegant, efficient stone tools using a technique — preparing a flint core so a single strike pops off a perfect finished flake — that takes modern flint-knappers years to master. They controlled fire, made birch-bark glue, hunted the biggest and most dangerous animals on the steppe at close range with heavy thrusting spears. And at La Ferrassie, just up a side valley from Les Eyzies, they buried their dead — an entire group, adults and children, including a newborn, laid deliberately into pits. Whatever was or wasn't in their

heads, something in them refused to leave a body out for the hyenas. On Monday morning, in the museum at Les Eyzies, you will stand in front of the actual skeleton of a Neanderthal — look for the young one from Le Moustier — and I'd invite you to spend a moment just being a fellow person about it.

Then, somewhere around forty-five thousand years ago, new people walk in. Homo sapiens — anatomically, people exactly like the two of you and everyone else on this plane — arriving in Europe out of Africa by way of the Levant, in small bands, over thousands of years. Science used to call the European members of this wave Cro-Magnons, and here is my favorite piece of local trivia in the region: the term comes from a specific small rock shelter behind a hotel in Les Eyzies. In 1868, workers building the railway line — the very line that made the town reachable — dug into the shelter and found ancient skeletons with shell ornaments. A geologist named Louis Lartet excavated properly and found individuals including the famous so-called Old Man of Cro-Magnon, whose skull had healed injuries and a face ravaged by infection. He'd survived things that should have killed him, for years — which means people fed him, and kept him, and carried him along. Care is one of the oldest artifacts in the valley. The shelter sits maybe four hundred meters from where you'll be eating pastries from Pâtisserie Margot. Every time any human anywhere is called Cro-Magnon, they are being named after a spot behind a hotel in the village where you're buying lunch.

Now — the overlap. When the sapiens newcomers arrived, Neanderthals were already here, and had been for hundreds of thousands of years. The two kinds of human shared Europe, and plausibly this very valley, for several thousand years. What happened between them is one of the great open questions, but modern genetics has given us one astonishing hard fact: they met, and they had children. If you're of European or Asian descent, roughly one to two percent of your genome is Neanderthal. You are not going to visit the world of some extinct alien species this week. You're going to visit the in-laws. Given that you're headed to a wedding — a merging of two family lines at a château in the Périgord — there's something fitting about honeymooning, so to speak, in the valley where humanity did its most consequential intermarrying.

By around forty thousand years ago, the Neanderthals fade out as a distinct people — climate stress, thin numbers, absorption; the honest answer is we don't fully know — and the valley belongs to sapiens. And over the next thirty thousand years, through the deepest cold, wave after wave of cultures flourish here, each named — of course — for a Périgord site. The Gravettians, named for La Gravette near Bayac, the people of the Venus figurines. The Solutreans, with stone points so thin and symmetrical they ring like porcelain, a craftsmanship far beyond practical need. And finally, from about eighteen to twelve thousand years ago, the Magdalenians — pronounced mag-dah-lay-NYAN — named for the La Madeleine shelter on the Vézère, a few bends downstream from Lascaux. The Magdalenians are the high civilization of the Ice Age: needles and sewn clothing, spear-throwers that doubled a hunter's range, harpoons for the salmon runs, jewelry, flutes, trade networks moving seashells hundreds of kilometers inland — and art. Art absolutely

everywhere: carved into spear-throwers, engraved on pebbles, and painted, unforgettably, on the walls of the deep caves. Font-de-Gaume is theirs. Most of what you'll see Tuesday is theirs. Lascaux is a little earlier, but it belongs to the same long tradition.

A scale check, because numbers this large go slippery. Lascaux's paintings are very roughly twenty-one thousand years old at the oldest estimates, seventeen at the youngest. The pyramids of Giza are about four and a half thousand years old. So from the painters of Lascaux to the pharaohs is more than three times the distance from the pharaohs to your boarding passes. When people call this stuff ancient history, they're off by an order of category. This is before history had anywhere to stand. And yet — this is the part that will get you in the caves — the people are not remote. They had needles. They had music. They cared for their injured. They held their children up to leave handprints on cave walls. The distance is vast and the humanity is instant, and holding both of those at once is, I think, the real point of your Monday and Tuesday.

One more thing, because one of you is going to ask how anyone actually knows all this. A claim like "twenty thousand years ago the valley was steppe-tundra full of reindeer" sounds like guesswork until you see the evidence, which comes from three directions.

The first is the ground itself. Remember that people lived in the same rock shelters for tens of thousands of years, and every generation dropped things — bones, ash, broken tools, lost beads — onto the floor, and dust and roof-fall slowly buried each layer under the next. A long-occupied shelter like Laugerie-Basse or Le Moustier is therefore a book, read bottom to top: Neanderthal hearths in the deep chapters, Magdalenian needlework near the surface, sterile layers marking the centuries when cold or flood drove everyone out. The men who first dug here in the eighteen-sixties read the book with pickaxes and lost whole pages doing it; Denis Peyrony — pay-ro-NEE, the local schoolteacher who became the father-figure of French prehistory and founded your Monday museum in 1913 — taught the region to read it with trowels and patience instead. Nearly everything I've told you comes, ultimately, out of those layers, most of them within a bicycle ride of Les Eyzies.

The second is climate. Three independent natural archives were recording the Ice Age weather the whole time, all of them unattended. Ice cores from Greenland: every year's snowfall traps a sample of that year's air in bubbles — drill three kilometers down and you have an annual archive of the atmosphere going back over a hundred thousand years, readable like tree rings. Pollen: every lake bed and bog downwind of the Périgord has been cataloguing the vegetation for millennia, because each species' pollen grains are distinctive and nearly indestructible — a core of lake mud is a time-lapse film of the landscape flickering from tundra herbs to birch scrub to oak forest as the ice lets go. And the caves themselves: stalagmites grow in annual bands whose chemistry records temperature and rainfall — the limestone was keeping a weather diary the whole time the painters worked. Line all three archives up and they agree, year-band by year-band, and that agreement is why I can tell you with a straight face that the coldest depth of the last Ice Age peaked around twenty-one thousand years ago — right around the older estimates for Lascaux. The bulls may have been painted within sight of the worst weather this valley ever had. Art at the bottom of the cold.

The third is the strangest: the seasons of dead reindeer. Reindeer teeth grow in annual layers like tiny trees, and antlers grow and drop on a strict calendar that differs between males and females. So when archaeologists sift a hearth and find jaws and antler fragments, they can often say not just “they ate reindeer” but “they ate this reindeer in late autumn.” Do that across a whole shelter and you get the annual rhythm of a community — here in spring for the salmon run, upriver in autumn for the migration crossings. The Ice Age Périgord had a social calendar, reconstructed one tooth at a time. When you stand in the museum Monday looking at what seems like a dull case of jawbones, that case is a datebook.

To finish, lay the shape of your own week over all this deep time. On Sunday you’ll drive the Dordogne valley: the river, the cliffs, the castles on the cliffs. That’s the limestone wearing its medieval costume. On Monday you cross into the Vézère valley and go straight down the timeline: the museum at Les Eyzies to load the context, then Lascaux to see the masterpiece, then La Roque Saint-Christophe, where the whole story stacks up in one cliff — Neanderthal hearths at the bottom, a medieval fortress town at the top, fifty-five thousand years of tenancy in eighty vertical meters. Tuesday, Font-de-Gaume: the real thing, original paint, the emotional summit of the trip. Then a wedding in the green hills, which — after a week of burials and handprints and family trees forty thousand years deep — will feel less like a break from the theme and more like its conclusion. People finding each other and throwing a feast about it: the oldest continuously running event in the valley.

One last September note before I let you doze. You’re arriving in the sweet gap the French call the *rentrée* — the country has gone back to school and work, the August crowds are gone, but everything is still open and the weather is usually the year’s most gracious: warm afternoons, crisp mornings, and — watch for this — river mist. On Monday and Tuesday mornings, the Vézère often lies under a low white quilt of fog that burns off by mid-morning. If you see it from the car, you’re seeing the valley exactly as the Magdalenians saw it on ten thousand September mornings: cliffs floating on cloud, river hidden, world gone soft. It photographs beautifully and it costs nothing.

Next episode: four teenagers, a dog named Robot, a hole under a fallen pine tree — and the afternoon in 1940 when the modern world fell into the Ice Age. See you there.

END OF EPISODE 1 SCRIPT

Episode 1 pronunciation table (reference only — do not feed to TTS)

French	IPA	Respelling
Vézère	/ve.zɛʁ/	vay-ZAIR
Dordogne	/dɔʁ.dɔŋ/	dor-DON-yuh
Périgord (Noir)	/pe.ʁi.gɔʁ (nwaʁ)/	pay-ree-GOR (NWAR)
Périgueux	/pe.ʁi.gø/	pay-ree-GUH
Bergerac	/bɛʁ.ʒə.ʁak/	bair-zhuh-RACK
Sarlat	/saʁ.la/	sar-LAH
Font-de-Gaume	/fɔ̃ də gom/	fon-duh-GOHM
abri	/a.bʁi/	ah-BREE
La Micoque	/la mi.kɔk/	lah mee-KOCK
Le Moustier	/lə mus.tje/	luh moo-STYAY
La Ferrassie	/la fɛ.ʁa.si/	lah fair-ah-SEE
La Madeleine	/la mad.lɛn/	lah mad-LEN
La Gravette	/la gʁa.vɛt/	lah grah-VET
Magdalénien	/mag.da.le.njɛ̃/	mag-dah-lay-NYAN
Cro-Magnon	/kʁo.ma.ɲɔ̃/	kro-man-YON
Les Eyzies	/le.z_ɛ.zi/	layz-ay-ZEE
rentrée	/ʁɑ̃.tʁɛ/	rahn-TRAY

Episode 2 — The Painted World

Listen on the plane. Part two of three. Approx. 30 minutes.

Production note: the cave art episode — the discovery of Lascaux, how and possibly why the paintings were made, the dating science, the conservation tragedy that explains why Monday is a replica and Tuesday is real. Slow the TTS slightly for this one if your engine allows it.

SCRIPT

September the eighth, 1940. Keep the date in your head, because you're going to be in the Périgord almost exactly eighty-six years later, nearly to the day.

France has fallen. The armistice is ten weeks old; the Dordogne sits in the unoccupied zone, full of refugees and rationing and dread. And in the small river town of Montignac — pronounced mon-teen-YACK — an eighteen-year-old garage apprentice named Marcel Ravidat — rah-vee-DAH — is out walking on the hill above town with his dog. The dog's name — and this is documented — is Robot. Robot goes down a hole. The hole sits where an old pine tree blew down years before, tearing open the ground, and local legend has always said there's a tunnel under the hill — maybe leading to buried treasure of the old manor. Ravidat pulls the dog out, notes the spot, and comes back four days later, September twelfth, with three friends — Jacques Marsal, Georges Agnel, Simon Coencas — a homemade oil lamp, and a knife to widen the hole.

He drops through a fifteen-meter scramble of rubble and finds himself in a large dark chamber.

He lifts the lamp. And out of the darkness above his head surge the bulls.

Bulls the size of cars — one of them over five meters long, still the largest single figure ever found in cave art anywhere. Horses at full gallop. Stags with antlers like candelabras. Not scratches, not smudges — vast, confident, finished paintings, oxide-red and charcoal-black and ochre-yellow, wrapped across the white calcite ceiling like weather. Four teenage boys, in the worst month of the worst year of the twentieth century, standing under the most beautiful room left behind by the Ice Age. Marsal said later that the paintings seemed to be moving in the lamplight. Hold onto that detail; it may turn out to be the whole secret, and I'll come back to it.

They told their schoolmaster; the schoolmaster told the one man in France you'd want told. The abbé Henri Breuil — ah-BAY BROY — a priest and the world's leading authority on prehistoric art, who happened to be sheltering nearby from the war. Breuil arrived within days, looked, and pronounced it genuine and supreme. The nickname he helped hang on it stuck: the Sistine Chapel of Prehistory. Two of those boys, by the way, became the cave's lifelong guardians — Jacques Marsal spent most of the rest of his life as a guide and protector of Lascaux, having essentially never left the hill he fell into at fourteen. And one more turn of the story, since the war never stays out of it: Simon Coencas was Jewish, and

survived internment at Drancy by the thinnest of margins before going into hiding. He lived until 2020 — the last of the four, an old man who as a boy had been one of the first modern humans to see the bulls.

The full inventory of Lascaux — pronounced lass-KOH — comes to about six hundred painted figures and close to six thousand engraved ones, through a couple hundred meters of chambers and passages. Almost entirely animals — horses most numerous, then aurochs, the giant wild cattle, then stags, ibex, bison, a few big cats deep in the back, one bear, one woolly rhinoceros. One strange spotted two-horned creature nobody can identify, nicknamed the unicorn. And exactly one human figure in the entire cave — stick-thin, bird-headed, falling backward in front of a wounded bison, next to a bird on a pole. Down a shaft, in the least accessible spot in the cave. Nobody knows what it means. Everybody who sees it knows it means something. You'll stand in front of it Monday, and I'll say more in the short episode that day.

The dates: somewhere between seventeen and twenty-one thousand years old, on the cusp between the Solutrean and Magdalenian cultures you met in episode one. The dating rests on two techniques, and if you're the one who always asks how they know, this part is for you. First, radiocarbon dating — where the art itself contains charcoal, or where hearths and lamps and pigment-stained tools litter the floor, you can count carbon-fourteen decay like a clock; Lascaux's floor was generously littered. Second, for caves where the art is pure mineral pigment with no carbon to date — and Font-de-Gaume is largely in this camp — you date the thin films of calcite that have dripped over the paintings since they were made. Calcite locks in traces of uranium, uranium decays to thorium on a known schedule, so a calcite skin over a bison gives you a minimum age: the painting must be older than the drip. It's dating by counting atomic grains of sand through the world's slowest hourglass, and it's the technique that produced the biggest shock in the field: the cave of Chauvet — shoh-VEH — far east of the Dordogne, painted with complete assurance thirty-six thousand years ago — twice the age of Lascaux, twice as far from Lascaux as Lascaux is from us — and every bit as accomplished. Cave art didn't crawl upward from crude to fine, the way the Victorians assumed. It arrives in the record already brilliant. Which rearranges the question from how did they learn to paint, to something far more interesting: what was painting for?

The how comes before the why, because the engineering is half the wonder.

Start with the paint. There are no tubes in the Ice Age. The palette is the earth itself: ochres — iron oxides — for the reds, yellows, and browns; manganese oxides for the blacks; at Lascaux the blacks are mostly manganese rather than charcoal, one reason dating it stays contentious. The painters ground these minerals to powder on stone palettes, mixed them with water, cave clay, sometimes animal fat, and applied them with every technique in the modern kit: fingers, hide pads, brushes of hair or chewed twig, and — most hauntingly — the airbrush. They'd load pigment into a hollow bird bone, or straight into their mouths, and spray a controlled mist. Much of Lascaux is spray-painted. When you see the soft gradient on a horse's belly on Monday, that's someone's breath, held and released twenty thousand years ago, still hanging on the wall.

Now the logistics, because this is where it stops being doodling and becomes a project. Parts of Lascaux's ceiling are five, six meters up. In the painted galleries, archaeologists found sockets cut into the rock walls — mortises for wooden beams. Scaffolding. Someone felled trees, hauled timber into a pitch-black cave, and built work platforms, exactly the way Michelangelo would, seventeen thousand years before Michelangelo. They lit the work with stone lamps burning animal tallow — a beautiful carved red sandstone lamp was found in the shaft, and you'll see lamps like it in the museum Monday morning — plus pine torches. Pigments had to be sourced, some from kilometers away; there's evidence of heating ochre to shift its color. Add it up: raw material supply chains, tool manufacture, lighting technology, carpentry, division of labor, and almost certainly apprenticeship — you don't paint a five-meter aurochs correctly on the first try. Whatever the caves were, the community poured its surplus into them the way medieval towns poured surplus into cathedrals, and Breuil's Sistine Chapel line was more precise than he knew.

And the painters knew things about their subjects that took science until basically now to verify. One example: many cave horses, including some at Lascaux, are painted with spotted leopard-like coats, and for a century scholars said, obviously symbolic, horses don't come like that. Then in 2011 geneticists pulled DNA from Ice Age horse bones and found the leopard-spotting gene. The horses did come like that. The painters were right, and the professors were wrong, and I find that outcome deeply satisfying. Watch for it Monday: these are not generic animals, they're portraits of a specific fauna — winter coats on the horses, the beard on the aurochs, antlers in autumn condition. Which, incidentally, is one of the ways we know a lot of this art engages with seasons — some scholars read parts of Lascaux as organized around the migration year: horses in spring condition here, stags in autumn rut there. You're visiting in September. On the Ice Age calendar painted on those walls, that's stag season and salmon season. You're arriving on time.

So why crawl hundreds of meters into the dark to paint animals you could see out the front door of your rock shelter?

Honest answer up front: nobody knows, and anyone who tells you otherwise is selling a book. But the theories are a pleasure in themselves, so here are the five main ones — none fully proven, none fully dead.

The oldest: art for art's sake. They painted because it's glorious and humans like glorious things. Almost certainly true as far as it goes — but it doesn't explain the location. You don't hang your art where no one can see it, in places that take ropes and lamps and crawling to reach.

Breuil's own theory: hunting magic. Paint the beast to capture the beast; some animals do seem marked with wounds or projectiles. But there's a famous inconvenient fact, and you'll be living it all week: the painters of the Vézère ate reindeer, overwhelmingly — the bone piles outside the shelters are wall-to-wall reindeer. The walls, though, are horses and bison and aurochs. Almost no reindeer. At Lascaux, effectively none. They did not paint their dinner. Whatever the animals on the walls are, they aren't a menu.

Third, the structuralist reading: the caves are organized cosmology — certain species paired with certain species, certain animals assigned to entrances, depths, and shafts. Statistically, the patterns are real; horses and bison do keep specific company across hundreds of caves. What the grammar says, we can't read. But the fact that there is a grammar at all tells you the painters were working inside a system of rules.

Fourth, the one with the most modern momentum: the shamanic theory. The deep cave as the membrane between worlds; the paintings made in — or about — trance states, the animals as spirit-beings emerging from the rock. Its evidence includes the way so many figures use the natural rock — a bulge becoming a shoulder, a crack becoming a horn, as if the animal were already in the wall and merely traced — and those abstract dot-and-grid signs that recur across caves and match the geometric hallucinations all human nervous systems produce in early trance. It's seductive, it fits a lot, and it's unfalsifiable, which makes scientists itchy. Take it as a strong maybe.

And fifth, the newest: information. Researchers have catalogued the abstract signs — dots, strokes, quadrilaterals — and found a small stable vocabulary repeating across all of Ice Age Europe for twenty thousand years. One recent, hotly debated proposal reads dot-and-line sequences next to animals as a phenological calendar — roughly, notes on how many lunar months after spring the species mates or migrates or births. If even a version of that holds up, then the caves are, among other things, humanity's first databases, and writing has a twenty-thousand-year prologue scratched next to a horse in the Dordogne. The jury is very much out. But standing in front of a panel wondering whether you're looking at a prayer or a spreadsheet — that's a good problem to have on a Monday.

And one more thing that isn't a theory, just a fact I want you to carry in: the children. Cave floors and walls across the region preserve children's footprints and small handprints, sometimes high up, where an adult must have lifted them. Whatever happened in the caves, children were brought along, held up, included. When the guide's flashlight finds a handprint Tuesday, remember it's as likely to be a nine-year-old's as a shaman's — and that somebody's parent was doing the lifting. Twenty thousand years before your wedding week, and the family unit is right there on the wall.

Two more rooms of this world before the tragedy, because the paintings are only the loudest part of the art.

First: the engravings. One number surprises people — at Lascaux, the engraved figures vastly outnumber the painted ones, and whole caves nearby, like Combarelles, are almost entirely engraved: hundreds upon hundreds of figures scratched into the rock with flint, some bold as woodcuts, some so fine you need raking light to catch them. Engraving may actually be the workhorse medium of the Ice Age, with paint as the gala format. Keep that in mind at both caves: whenever the light rakes sideways, look for the scratch-lines riding under and over the pigment. Often the painting sits on an engraved sketch — underdrawing, exactly as an art teacher would demand — and sometimes the engraving

corrects the paint. Somebody, seventeen thousand years ago, looked at a nearly finished horse, decided the jaw was wrong, and fixed it. That small act of revision might be the most relatable thing in either cave.

Second: the hands. All over Ice Age Europe — less at Lascaux, famously at other caves — people left hand stencils: palm to the wall, pigment sprayed over, a negative print that reads across the millennia as unmistakably as a wave. And the hands have been talking to science lately. Measure the finger-length ratios and many of those hands are plausibly female, which rearranged a century of assumptions about who made this art; the old picture of the lone male shaman-artist now has to share the scaffold. Other prints are children's, held up by someone taller. Some hands show missing finger segments — frostbite, ritual, or fingers folded down as a signal code; nobody knows. The one thing a hand stencil can't be is anonymous-in-general: each one was a specific person, on a specific cold day, saying the oldest sentence there is — I was here.

And third, briefly: the sound. The Ice Age had music — actual instruments survive, bone flutes elsewhere in Europe with true finger holes, and from this wider world, whistles and bullroarers. And researchers who've mapped cave acoustics report something suggestive: in several caves, panels of art cluster near points of strong resonance — where a voice or a drum booms most richly. It's contested, like everything in this field. But stand in the Hall of the Bulls on Monday and try to imagine the room as it may actually have run: firelight moving, animals flickering in and out of the dark, and sound — chant, drum, drone — rolling off the calcite. A painted cave may have worked less like a museum and more like an opera house. Then the house lights come up, and we reach the part of the story where the twentieth century breaks the spell.

Now for the tragedy — because you need it to understand why your Monday ticket says Lascaux four, not Lascaux.

After the war, the cave was fitted with a door, stairs, lighting, and opened to the public in 1948. It became one of the wonders of the world overnight — up to a couple thousand visitors a day at the peak, more than a million people over fifteen years. Picasso reputedly came out saying, in effect, we have invented nothing. And every single visitor exhaled.

The mechanism is painfully elegant. A sealed cave is a stable system: constant fourteen-to-sixteen degrees, saturated humidity, almost no airflow. The paintings had survived seventeen thousand years because nothing changed. Then suddenly: a thousand humans a day, each one a walking furnace radiating a hundred watts, each exhaling warm, damp carbon dioxide by the lungful, each shedding skin flakes and pollen and spores. The carbon dioxide plus moisture formed exactly what episode one taught you to fear — carbonic acid, condensing on the walls, the same chemistry that carved the caves now dissolving the paint. Body heat set up air currents the cave had never known. Green algae began creeping across the walls — *la maladie verte*, the green sickness. Then a white crust of calcite began to grow over paintings. The cave that had preserved humanity's masterpiece for seventeen millennia was being destroyed in fifteen years by admiration.

In 1963, André Malraux — France's culture minister; remember the name, he saves Sarlat with a different law, that's episode three — shut Lascaux. Permanently. The decision was agonizing and correct, and the crises kept coming anyway: a fungal invasion in 2001, black mold spots in the two thousands, each fought back by a permanent scientific council that now runs the cave like an intensive-care patient — sealed, climate-monitored, entered only rarely, by a handful of people, for minutes at a time. You and I will never see the real Lascaux. That door has closed for our species' foreseeable future, and it closed because a million of us loved it wrong.

This is where the story turns back toward you two. The French response to losing the cave was to remake it, perfectly, twice. Lascaux two, opened in 1983 beside the original hill, reproduced the two great galleries and was for decades one of the most-visited replicas on earth. And then Lascaux four — your Monday, opened in 2016 at the foot of the hill — is the full-scale endgame: virtually the entire decorated cave, rebuilt from laser scans accurate to fractions of a millimeter, the art repainted by teams of artists over years, using the original palette of pigments, on sculpted panels that reproduce every bump and crack of the rock — because remember, the painters used the bumps and cracks, so a flat copy would be a lie. The temperature is held cave-cool at sixteen degrees, the light is kept torch-dim, on purpose. It is, by broad consent, the best replica of anything, anywhere.

If the word replica itches, consider a great orchestra playing a symphony whose manuscript is locked in a vault: the performance is real even when the paper stays home. And your specific format — the self-guided visit with audioguide, just the two of you setting the pace — is the best way this site can be seen now. The historical complaints about Lascaux four were rushed groups and fixed pacing. You've accidentally bought the version with neither. Stand under the bulls as long as you like. That's a luxury the cave itself never offered anyone, including the Magdalenians, who worked by guttering lamplight in cramped air.

Which brings us to Tuesday, and I'll keep this short because it gets its own episode on the walk-up. Font-de-Gaume, in the hill right above Les Eyzies, is the other side of the bargain: the last cave in France with polychrome paintings — the full multi-color, Lascaux-class art — that you can still walk into and see original. Not a copy, not a projection: the actual pigment, laid on by actual hands, fourteen thousand-ish years ago, with the actual darkness of the actual hill pressing in around you. About two hundred figures, bison above all — a famous frieze of five — and one image, a reindeer tenderly licking the forehead of another, that has made more archaeologists cry than they'd admit in print. Numbers are capped at a few dozen visitors a day, cut year by year for conservation, and the honest expectation is that someday, maybe soon, Font-de-Gaume closes like Lascaux closed. You two have tickets for eleven fifteen on a Tuesday in September while the door is still open. Your grandchildren may know these paintings the way you'll know Lascaux — through a magnificent copy. You'll be able to tell them you stood in the room.

That's the design of the week: Monday for comprehension — the museum gives you the language, the replica gives you the whole text, bright-lit and at your own pace. Tuesday for presence — dimmer, briefer, guided, and irreplaceable. It's the right order.

Last thought before you stretch your legs. Remember Marsal saying the paintings seemed to move in the lamplight? Researchers have taken that seriously in recent years — because under a flickering flame, with the eye’s persistence, many of these figures are built to move. Multiple superimposed legs on the horses. Sequential heads. The animals painted across curved surfaces so a walking viewer sees them stride. There’s a respectable argument that what you’ll see Monday is humanity’s first animation — figures designed for a moving light source and a moving audience, twenty thousand years before anyone said cinema. Four boys and a dog fell through the ceiling of the world’s oldest movie theater, in 1940, while the world burned. The projector still runs.

Next episode: we let the ice melt, plant some walnut trees, and watch England and France spend a hundred years fighting over the exact riverbank where you’ll be eating lunch on Sunday. Also: the physics of confit. See you there.

END OF EPISODE 2 SCRIPT

Episode 2 pronunciation table (reference only — do not feed to TTS)

French	IPA	Respelling
Lascaux	/las.ko/	lass-KOH
Montignac	/mɔ̃.ti.ɲak/	mon-teen-YACK
Marcel Ravidat	/maʁ.sɛl ʁa.vi.da/	mar-SELL rah-vee-DAH
Jacques Marsal	/ʒak maʁ.sal/	ZHACK mar-SALL
abbé Breuil	/a.be bʁœj/	ah-BAY BROY
Chauvet	/ʃo.vɛ/	shoh-VEH
Font-de-Gaume	/fɔ̃ də gom/	fon-duh-GOHM
la maladie verte	/la ma.la.di vɛʁt/	lah mah-lah-DEE VAIRT
André Malraux	/ɑ̃.dʁe mal.ʁo/	ahn-DRAY mal-ROH
Les Eyzies	/le.z_ɛ.zi/	layz-ay-ZEE

Episode 3 — Duck Fat and Gunpowder

Listen on the plane. Part three of three. Approx. 30 minutes.

Production note: the medieval-history and food episode. Covers the Eleanor of Aquitaine backstory, the Hundred Years' War as it plays out on Sunday's castles, the bastides, and then the full food-and-terroir briefing including September seasonality and market etiquette.

SCRIPT

Welcome back. Last episode ended in the dark, fourteen thousand years ago, with a reindeer licking another reindeer's forehead. This episode ends with dinner. In between: about a thousand years of people fighting over the exact stretch of riverbank where you two will be eating lunch on Sunday, and the story of how a landscape at war became a landscape of walnut groves and duck fat and the best market towns in France. The connective tissue, as ever, is the limestone. The cliffs that sheltered the Magdalenians turn out to be equally good at holding castles, and the caves that held paintings turn out to be equally good at aging cheese and hiding Protestants. Nothing in the Périgord is ever used only once.

Fast-forward through the ice melting. Forests return, the reindeer follow the cold north forever, and the hunter-artists' descendants — plus new arrivals — learn farming. The valley never empties; it just keeps switching costumes. The Gauls of the Petrocorii give the region its name and put up a good fight against Julius Caesar. Rome builds a city at Périgueux with an amphitheater and a great circular temple whose tower still stands. Christianity arrives, abbeys sprout — Sarlat itself begins as a Benedictine abbey around the ninth century, allegedly holding relics of Saint Sacerdos. Vikings actually raid up the Dordogne and Vézère rivers in the ninth century — longships this far inland, four hundred kilometers from the sea, which tells you something about both Viking nerve and how navigable your Sunday river really is. People shelter, once again, in the cliffs; the fortress at La Roque Saint-Christophe gets its first serious walls precisely to watch for dragon-prowed ships coming round the bend.

But the story that carves your Sunday itinerary into shape begins with a wedding. Fitting, given why you're flying over.

In 1137, the Duke of Aquitaine dies on pilgrimage, leaving everything to his daughter Eleanor — Aliénor in the local tongue, ah-lyay-NOR — who at fifteen is suddenly the greatest heiress in Europe. Aquitaine — ah-kee-TEN — amounts to a third of France, including every inch of the Dordogne. She's married within months to the King of France, Louis the Seventh. It goes badly. He's monkish; she's brilliant, political, worldly — she rides on Crusade with him and comes back openly unimpressed. After fifteen years and no sons, the marriage is annulled in March of 1152.

Eight weeks later — eight weeks — Eleanor marries Henry Plantagenet, a nineteen-year-old with red hair, boundless energy, and a claim on the English throne. Two years after that, he's crowned King Henry the Second of England. One consequence of that wedding detonates three centuries of history: Eleanor's dowry goes with her. The King of England now rules more of France than the King of France — including the entire Dordogne. From that wedding until 1453 — three hundred years — the southwest is the fault line where the two crowns grind against each other, and your Sunday river is, for long stretches, the actual border. That's the sound you'll be hearing under everything on Sunday afternoon: one bad marriage and one brilliant remarriage, echoing off the cliffs.

The grinding starts immediately — Eleanor and Henry's own sons rebel, and their most famous son, Richard the Lionheart, spends years stomping around the Périgord subduing local barons, including, for a time, taking Beynac — pronounced bay-NACK — the castle you'll storm at four fifteen on Sunday. But the main event is the Hundred Years' War, 1337 to 1453, when the simmer becomes open dynastic war. The Dordogne's version of the war involved few set-piece battles of the Agincourt kind. It ran on castles, raids, and protection rackets — a cold war with hot edges, fought valley by valley for four generations.

Sunday afternoon, you get its perfect stage set. Château de Beynac, on the north bank, glowering French. And directly across the river — you'll see it plainly from the ramparts and even better from the gardens at Marqueyssac — the Château de Castelnaud — pronounced kass-tel-NOH — which spent most of the war in English hands. Two fortresses, in sight of each other, close enough that on a still day each could hear the other's bells, held by opposite sides in a century of war. Between them, the river, the fords, the tolls, and the peasants trying to get a harvest in. The castles traded raids, spies, and the occasional sortie for decades. Standing on Beynac's ramparts looking across at Castelnaud is the single best cold-war viewpoint of the middle ages anywhere in Europe, and you'll have it in late-afternoon light.

While you're up there, notice what a medieval castle actually is, because Beynac is an unusually honest one — never prettified into a Renaissance palace. It's a machine, and the machine's product is control of movement. The keep is twelfth-century, walls up to a couple meters thick, on a cliff a hundred and fifty meters above the river. From that height you see everything that moves on the water and the valley road, and everything that moves pays. River tolls, road tolls, market rights, mill rights — a castle is a tollbooth with a sword. That's why they cluster along this river like beads: the Dordogne was the highway, and the highway was worth taxing. And notice the human scale inside — the rooms are small, dark, cold. Even for the lords of one of the four great baronies of Périgord, which Beynac was, medieval luxury was mostly the luxury of being the one doing the taxing.

Now, the war's supporting cast, because you'll be sleeping inside two pieces of it. First: the bastides — pronounced bass-TEED. In the decades before the war, both crowns went on a town-founding spree across the southwest — hundreds of brand-new planned towns, laid out at a stroke on a grid around a central arcaded market square. Militarily they staked territory; economically they were startup incubators: settlers got a plot, tax breaks, and a charter of liberties, in exchange for showing up and making the place real. The French king

Philip the Third — or his brother, sources argue — founded Domme — DOM — in 1281 as a French royal bastide on a cliff four hundred feet over the river, staring across at what would become English country. You'll be there Sunday at sunset-ish. Look at the street plan when you walk in: it's a grid, or at least a grid negotiating with a clifftop — the surveyor's straight lines bending where the rock says no. It's the thirteenth century's idea of a master-planned community, and it still works: the market square still holds a market, seven hundred and forty years later.

Domme also hides the region's darkest footnote. In 1307, when King Philip the Fair destroyed the Knights Templar in a single coordinated dawn raid — Friday the thirteenth of October, the origin of the superstition, though scholars roll their eyes at the connection — dozens of Templars were imprisoned in Domme's gate towers for years awaiting trial. They carved graffiti into the walls: crosses, Grails, crucifixions, geometric prayers, still visible today scratched into the stone of the Porte des Tours. Men on the losing side of history, carving prayers into its walls, in a town built as a border weapon. The Périgord keeps everything.

Second piece of supporting cast: Sarlat — pronounced sar-LAH — your Sunday night and Monday morning. Sarlat was the abbey town that became the administrative heart of the French Périgord, and it earned its stone the hard way: besieged, raided, ransomed, and rebuilt across both the Hundred Years' War and, later, the Wars of Religion, when Protestant and Catholic armies took turns at it in the fifteen hundreds — the same wars, incidentally, that finally destroyed the cliff city at La Roque Saint-Christophe in 1588, ending fifty-five thousand years of continuous occupancy on one order from one king. When the wars finally ended, Sarlat rebuilt in golden limestone in the style of its best decades, and then history forgot it. Trade routes moved, the railway mostly passed by, and the town was too poor to modernize, which is the best preservative there is. More on the second miracle, the 1962 law that saved it, in Monday morning's episode — it involves Malraux again, the same man who closed Lascaux. One career, two acts of salvage.

And Sarlat gives you a resident worth meeting over dinner: Étienne de La Boétie — pronounced ay-TYEN duh lah bo-ay-SEE — born there in 1530, in an ornamented Renaissance house you'll walk past Monday morning, fifty meters from your hotel. At about eighteen he wrote the Discourse on Voluntary Servitude, one of the founding documents of political philosophy — the argument that tyrants hold power only because people consent to give it, and that the remedy is not rebellion but simple, coordinated refusal. Every civil-disobedience movement since — Thoreau, Tolstoy, Gandhi — stands downstream of a teenager from Sarlat. He died at thirty-two, and his best friend sat by the deathbed and was so marked by the loss that he spent the rest of his life writing about how to live and die well. The friend was Michel de Montaigne, the essays are the Essays, and when Montaigne tried to explain the friendship, he produced the most famous sentence about friendship in the French language: because it was he, because it was I. That's the town you'll have a duck dinner in on Sunday. Try to walk past the La Boétie house twice — evening floodlight and morning sun.

Before the cannons end it, one more figure from the war years, and I'm giving him to you because your Monday dinner plan drives straight past his front gate: Bertran de Born — pronounced bair-TRAHN duh BORN — lord of Hautefort — oat-FOR — the hilltop village where you're aiming to have dinner on Monday night. In the late twelfth century, Bertran was one of the most celebrated troubadours in Europe — the poet-knights of the south who more or less invented the love song — except Bertran's specialty wasn't love. It was war. He wrote gorgeous, appalling verses about how spring is sweet because campaigning season is starting, and how the sight of besieged castles gladdens the heart — the twelfth century's greatest war correspondent, embedded on his own side. He feuded with his own brother over Hautefort itself, egged on the sons of Eleanor and Henry in their rebellions — Richard the Lionheart was alternately his enemy and his patron — and generally treated the Plantagenet family drama as both raw material and personal chessboard. Dante was so scandalized, a century later, that he placed Bertran deep in the Inferno carrying his own severed head like a lantern — punished as a sower of discord between kin. All of which is to say: when you drive up toward that castle silhouette above Hautefort on Monday evening for a quiet three-course dinner, you're dining in the shadow of the man who taught Europe to sing about exactly the wars whose castles you toured on Sunday. Raise a glass to him; from a safe distance of eight centuries, he's excellent company.

One correction to all this castle romance, because it's easy to hear a century of war as adventure: for the people who grew the food, the Hundred Years' War in the Périgord was mostly the routiers — roo-TYAY — freelance mercenary companies who, between official campaigns, simply didn't stop. They occupied castles, taxed valleys at swordpoint, and sold protection against themselves. Villages fortified their churches — you'll see church towers all week with arrow slits, which should strike you as theologically odd until you remember what they were for. Some communities dug refuge tunnels under their houses; some went back into the cliffs, into the same shelters as their ancestors of the ice. The region's population may have fallen by half across the fourteenth century, between war, plague, and the hunger that follows both. The golden villages you're driving through are survivors' architecture: built, burned, rebuilt, and finally — after 1453 — allowed to just be farms again. The prettiness is earned.

The war ends with gunpowder, and it ends practically inside your Thursday itinerary. By the fourteen-forties, France has done something new: a standing professional artillery corps, the Bureau brothers' cannon train, the best in the world. Castles like Beynac and Castelnaud — designed against ladders, arrows, and patience — are suddenly obsolete; stone that shrugged off catapults cracks under iron cannonballs. In July 1453, the last English field army in the southwest, under the seventy-ish-year-old veteran John Talbot, charges a fortified French artillery camp at Castillon, on the Dordogne river — about ten kilometers from Saint-Émilion, where you'll be sipping wine on Thursday afternoon. The guns shred the charge; Talbot is killed under his horse. Castillon is the last battle of the Hundred Years' War — the war ends where your trip ends, and the town is still called Castillon-la-Bataille. Bordeaux surrenders three months later, and three hundred years of English Aquitaine are over. When you raise a glass in Saint-Émilion, you'll be doing it on the doorstep of the battlefield that decided whose language the waiter would greet you in.

That's the gunpowder half. Now the duck fat, because the same geography that made the war made the food, and your route runs down one of the great eating roads of Europe.

Périgord cuisine is preservation cuisine. It's what a landlocked, hilly, hot-summer, cold-winter region invents when it has abundance in October and needs to eat until April, in the centuries before refrigeration. Every icon on the menu is a solved physics problem.

Start with confit — pronounced kon-FEE. You take duck or goose legs, salt them for a day — salt pulls water out of the meat by osmosis, and microbes need water — then cook them slowly, submerged in their own rendered fat, and pot them up still under that fat. The fat sets into an airtight, waterproof seal; no air, no water, no microbes, no spoilage. A crock of confit in a cool Périgord cellar keeps for months and improves — enzymes keep gently tenderizing the meat all winter. It is canning, invented before cans, and it's why duck fat, not butter or olive oil, is the cooking fat of the region. Which brings us to the greatest side dish in France: pommes sarladaises — pronounced pom sar-lah-DEZ — potatoes in the style of Sarlat, crisped in duck fat with garlic and parsley. Duck fat's mix of fats stays liquid enough to crisp beautifully at high heat; science struggles to improve on it. You will be offered these approximately daily. Accept approximately daily; you'll walk it off on the castle stairs.

Then the difficult one, and let's be grown-ups about it: foie gras — pronounced fwah-GRAH — the fattened liver of duck or goose, the region's flagship and its controversy. The technique of fattening waterfowl is ancient — the Egyptians noticed geese gorge naturally before migration, storing energy in the liver, and the practice runs through Rome to here, where corn's arrival from the New World made the Périgord its world capital. Modern production intensifies that natural gorging by hand-feeding, and you should know that welfare objections to it are serious and I won't argue them away. I'll only give you the local context: in the Périgord this is overwhelmingly small-farm culture, geese and ducks in actual meadows, and the farmer at a market stall will happily talk husbandry with you, and the semi-cooked mi-cuit on a slice of bread with a glass of sweet Monbazillac is, purely as chemistry and pleasure, extraordinary. Decide as you see fit; you'll eat superbly either way, because duck in all its unarguable forms — the confit, and the seared rosy breast called magret — mah-GRAY — a preparation only invented in the nineteen-sixties — carries the menu regardless.

Next, the walnut — la noix, pronounced nwah. This is the tree crop of the Périgord, with its own appellation like a fine wine, and it's everywhere in your week: walnut groves line the Vézère road, walnut bread at the markets, walnut oil in the salads, walnuts in the cake, and vin de noix — pronounced van-duh-NWAH — an aperitif of green walnuts steeped in wine and eau-de-vie that you should order once at Essendiéras just to say you did. Walnut oil was medieval liquid gold — it lit lamps, paid tithes, and moved downriver on the flat-bottomed gabarre boats you'll see at La Roque-Gageac. And your timing is sharp: the harvest starts in late September. The nets are going out under the trees the week you're there.

The truffle requires expectation management. Yes, the Périgord gave its name to the black winter truffle; yes, it's a wonder — a subterranean fungus married to oak roots, trading sugars for minerals in the dark, announcing its ripeness by synthesizing a molecule so close to a pig pheromone that sows go berserk for it, which is why tradition used pigs and sense used dogs, who unlike pigs don't try to eat the merchandise. But note the word winter. Truffle season is December to February. A market stall selling "truffle products" in September is selling you last winter in a jar, at tourist prices. Skip it without regret, because September hands you something better: the cèpe — pronounced SEP — the porcini of the Périgord. If rain has come in the fortnight before your visit, mid-September is peak cèpe, whole market tables of fat brown boletes, and every blackboard menu in Sarlat will say omelette aux cèpes. That is the correct answer to at least one dinner decision this week. Locals guard their gathering spots like bank codes; asking a Périgourdin where he found his cèpes is about as welcome as asking his salary.

And to drink: you're bracketed by two wine worlds. Thursday you get the aristocrat, Saint-Émilion — full briefing in its own episode, including why the harvest may be happening around you as you drive in. But give the local underdog its due some evening: Bergerac, the Dordogne's own vineyard, unfairly overshadowed by grand Bordeaux next door — same grapes, gentler prices — and above all golden Monbazillac — pronounced mon-bah-zee-YACK — a sweet wine made from grapes deliberately left to be attacked by a fungus — Botrytis, boh-TRY-tiss, the noble rot — which shrivels them into candied intensity on the vine. The pairing with foie gras is centuries old here; when a waiter suggests it, say yes.

Last piece, and it doubles as your Sunday-morning briefing: the market. Your very first stop in the region — before any castle, any cave — is the Sunday market at Saint-Cyprien — pronounced san-see-pree-AN — and that's the right order of operations, because the weekly market is the region's true institution, older than most of its castles; it's where the bastide squares earn their keep and where the whole food story above is lying on tables. Three rules of French market etiquette, worth rehearsing on the plane. One: say bonjour — bon-ZHOOR — to the stallholder before anything else; in France the greeting opens the transaction, and skipping it reads as rude rather than merely brisk. Two: don't handle the produce — point, and the seller picks for you; it's their craft and their stock. Three: carry some cash and unhurried manners — taste what's offered, buy small and often, and say merci beaucoup — mair-SEE boh-KOO — on the way out. Do those three things and the Périgord will treat you like family. Which, per episode one and a certain percentage of your genome, you technically are.

That completes the overview: a hundred million years of limestone, twenty thousand years of painters, a thousand years of castles, and confit as the physics of surviving winter. Tomorrow you'll be on a train south doing three hundred kilometers an hour across all of it, and that ride has its own episode — the backbone tape, the long one. For now: the cabin lights are probably down, you land in the morning, and somewhere south of Paris a valley that has been hosting humans for four hundred thousand years has set two more places at the table. Sleep well. It'll keep. It's good at that.

END OF EPISODE 3 SCRIPT

Episode 3 pronunciation table (reference only — do not feed to TTS)

French	IPA	Respelling
Aliénor (Eleanor)	/a.lje.nɔʁ/	ah-lyay-NOR
Aquitaine	/a.ki.tɛn/	ah-kee-TEN
Beynac	/bɛ.nak/	bay-NACK
Castelnaud	/kas.tɛl.no/	kass-tel-NOH
bastide	/bas.tid/	bass-TEED
Domme	/dɔm/	DOM
Porte des Tours	/pɔʁt de tuʁ/	PORT day TOOR
Sarlat	/saʁ.la/	sar-LAH
Étienne de La Boétie	/e.tjɛn də la bo.e.si/	ay-TYEN duh lah bo-ay-SEE
Montaigne	/mɔ̃.tɛɲ/	mon-TEN-yuh
Castillon	/kas.ti.jɔ̃/	kass-tee-YON
confit	/kɔ̃.fi/	kon-FEE
pommes sarladaises	/pɔm saʁ.la.dɛz/	POM sar-lah-DEZ
foie gras	/fwa ɡʁɑ/	fwah-GRAH
mi-cuit	/mi kuɪ/	mee-KWEE
magret	/ma.ɡʁɛ/	mah-GRAY
noix / vin de noix	/nwa/	NWAH / van-duh-NWAH
cèpe	/sɛp/	SEP
Monbazillac	/mɔ̃.ba.zi.jak/	mon-bah-zee-YACK
Bergerac	/bɛʁ.ʒə.vak/	bair-zhuh-RACK
Saint-Cyprien	/sɛ̃ si.pʁi.ɛ̃/	san-see-pree-AN
bonjour / merci beaucoup	/bɔ̃.ʒuʁ/ /mɛʁ.si bo.ku/	bon-ZHOOR / mair-SEE boh-KOO

Episode 4 — The Backbone: Paris to Bordeaux at Three Hundred Kilometers an Hour

Listen on the TGV, Saturday September 12. Approx. 45 minutes — about a third of the ride. Sit on the left side of the train heading south if you can; most of the landmarks below fall that way, and you get the afternoon light.

Production note: the audio tour for the Montparnasse → Bordeaux Saint-Jean TGV. Structured to run in rough sync with the journey: station, departure, then geography in order — Beauce, Loire, Poitou, Charente, Gironde — then a Bordeaux landing briefing keyed to their Saturday night and 07:00 Sunday car pickup. It is the longest episode: engineering, geology, history, wine science.

SCRIPT

If everything has gone to plan, you two are sitting in a train at Gare Montparnasse — pronounced gar mon-par-NAHSS — with your bags overhead, a wedding outfit somewhere in the luggage you are trying not to think about, and a departure board that says Bordeaux Saint-Jean. In roughly two hours and a bit, you will step off this train five hundred and eighty kilometers to the southwest, having crossed half of France — several major rivers, three ancient provinces, two climate zones, and about a hundred and fifty million years of geology — at speeds touching three hundred and twenty kilometers an hour — call it two hundred miles an hour — in a seat, with a coffee. This episode is the story of the machine you're sitting in, the country sliding past your window, and the city waiting at the end. It's the backbone tape: everything this week hangs off the line you're about to travel.

But before the train moves — the station. Montparnasse deserves two stories.

The first: this is the station of the most famous train accident photograph ever taken. October 1895 — the old station building, not this one — an express from Granville comes in late and fast, the driver trying to make up minutes. The air brake fails, the locomotive plows through the buffers, across the concourse, through a meter-thick stone facade, and nose-dives out of the building onto the street below, where it stands for days, vertical, absurd, while all of Paris comes to look. One woman on the street was killed — a newspaper seller; the railway pensioned her children — but every passenger survived, and the photograph of a steam engine planted face-first on a Paris sidewalk became one of the most reproduced images of the industrial age. You've seen it on posters and album covers. It happened here, roughly where you bought your croissant.

The second is quieter and better. August 1944, liberation of Paris: the German military governor, von Choltitz — fon KHOL-tits — who had, at least by the polished version, declined Hitler's order to burn the city — signed his surrender inside this station. Montparnasse is where the occupation of Paris formally ended. Stations collect history because everything passes through them; this one collected the end of a war and the invention of the disaster photo, and now it collects you two, heading to a wedding.

And Montparnasse has always been Paris's door to the southwest — the Breton station, the Atlantic station. Which is why, when France decided to point its high-speed revolution west and south, the new line grew from here.

Now the machine itself. One of you is going to spend at least ten minutes of this ride wondering what it's doing under the floor, so the engineering deserves to be done properly.

The TGV — train à grande vitesse, simply "high-speed train" — is one of the great unsung French masterpieces, up there with the caves and the confit. The first line opened in 1981, Paris to Lyon, and the concept rests on three decisions, all of which you'll feel in the next two hours.

The first: the track matters more than the train. A dedicated high-speed line — an LGV, *ligne à grande vitesse* — is a purpose-built road with no level crossings, no freight, no sharp curves, and no towns to thread. At three hundred kilometers an hour you cover eighty-three meters every second, so a curve you'd barely notice on a country railway would put your coffee in your lap; LGV curves are drawn with radii of six, seven kilometers, and gentle bankings, so the line rides the landscape like a drawn breath — long cuttings, long embankments, long viaducts, never a jink. The rail itself is continuously welded — no clickety-clack, because there are no joints to click; that eerie smoothness you're feeling is the absence of a sound humans associated with trains for a hundred and fifty years.

And the trainset is articulated: the cars share bogies — the wheel assemblies sit between carriages, not under each one — which makes the train a single stiff spine rather than a chain of wagons. That's the second decision, and the reason the ride feels less like a train than like a very low-flying aircraft. It has a grim virtue too — in derailment tests and a few real incidents, articulated TGVs have stayed upright and in line at extraordinary speeds.

The third decision is power: twenty-five thousand volts coming off that overhead wire into motors that would embarrass a small power station, in a train that still keeps its axle weight to about seventeen tonnes so it doesn't hammer the track it depends on. Light, stiff, powered like fury, on a road with no surprises.

As for the concept's ceiling: in April 2007, a specially tuned TGV with oversized wheels and a shortened set ran five hundred and seventy-four point eight kilometers an hour on the eastern line — about three hundred and fifty-seven miles an hour, the world record for conventional rail, a record that still stands. That's not your speed today; commercially the fleet cruises at three hundred to three hundred and twenty. But it tells you the margin the engineers are holding in reserve. You are traveling at a comfortable sixty percent of what this design has proven it can do.

How France got here is a story worth a minute, because it explains something real about the country you're crossing. France has a two-century-old cult of the state engineer — the great schools, the corps of bridges and roads, the conviction that infrastructure is a form of national literature. In 1955, on a dead-straight stretch of line south of Bordeaux — not far, incidentally, from where you'll land today — two French electric locomotives were run, on separate days, to three hundred and thirty-one kilometers an hour. The tests were half triumph, half warning: the speed was real, but the locomotives hunted and swayed viciously

and the overhead wire was left hanging in shreds behind them. The lesson France took was the right one — the trains could be made fast, but the whole system would have to be reinvented around the speed: track, wire, signaling, everything. It took twenty-five years, a detour through a gas-turbine prototype that the 1973 oil shock mercifully killed, and a bet-the-railway decision to electrify and build Paris-Lyon as a clean-sheet line. The TGV that opened in 1981 amounted to a new transport category wearing a train costume. Most countries never make that leap — they bolt speed onto old railroads and get old-railroad results. France rebuilt the premise. You're sitting in the conclusion.

And your particular stretch of track is the newest big piece of the network: the LGV Sud Europe Atlantique, three hundred-odd kilometers from Tours to Bordeaux, opened in July 2017 — one of the largest infrastructure projects in modern Europe, around eight billion euros, delivered through a giant public-private concession. Before it opened, Paris to Bordeaux took three hours on a good day. Now the fastest trains do it in about two hours and four minutes, and the consequence was immediate and dramatic: the plane lost. On routes under about three hours, high-speed rail simply beats flying — city center to city center, no security theater, no taxiing — and the Paris-Bordeaux air route withered almost overnight. France later banned short-haul flights where a rail alternative under two and a half hours exists, a law this line made thinkable. You are, right now, aboard the argument.

One more number, because it's the kind you two can trade over dinner this week: per seat, this train emits on the order of one-twentieth to one-fiftieth the carbon of the equivalent flight, because it runs on French electricity, which is mostly nuclear and hydro. The greenest fast machine in Europe, powered largely by atoms, carrying you to look at paintings made by firelight.

The train is moving, or about to, and the rest of this episode follows the window south.

First, the escape from Paris — fifteen-ish minutes of suburbs, graffiti, and commuter platforms while the train ambles on ordinary track. Somewhere out there to your right is Versailles. Feel free to ignore all of it; the show starts when the train reaches the high-speed line and the driver opens the tap. You'll know the moment. The acceleration is quiet but relentless — no engine roar, just the world's gears changing — and within a few minutes the landscape starts to pour past instead of sit there.

What's flowing past first is the Beauce — the great grain plain southwest of Paris, pool-table flat, horizon to horizon of wheat stubble by the time you see it in September. This is France's breadbasket and has been since the middle ages — the plain that fed Paris, dotted with grain silos standing where you'd expect castles. The flatness is geological: you're crossing the floor of the Paris Basin, a stack of sediments laid in yet another vanished sea. France, you'll find, is mostly vanished seas. If it's late afternoon, the light on the stubble does something Dutch painters spent careers chasing. Then, about an hour in, the land begins to gather itself into a wide green trench, and you cross the Loire.

The Loire — pronounced LWAR — is France's longest river, its last great wild one, all sandbanks and braided channels, and the trench it runs in is the Loire Valley: château country, the so-called garden of France, where the French Renaissance happened —

Chambord, Amboise, and the rest strung along the water east and west of your crossing. Leonardo da Vinci died in this valley, at Amboise, upstream to your left, having been imported by King Francis the First as the world's first celebrity acquisition, allegedly arriving with the Mona Lisa in his saddlebags — which is roughly why she lives in Paris today.

Your train threads past Tours — pronounced TOOR — the valley's capital, and file one connection: Tours is where your brand-new high-speed line begins. Everything from here to Bordeaux is the 2017 track — from this point on you're on the fast, silent, surprise-free road the whole way south. Settle in; the driver just got their favorite part.

South of the Loire the country changes texture — hedgerows, white cattle, goats — and you enter one of the great pieces of invisible geography in Europe: the *seuil du Poitou* — say it SOY, doo pwah-TOO — the Threshold of Poitou. France has two great masses of ancient hard rock — the Armorican massif under Brittany to the northwest, and the Massif Central to the southeast, the old volcanic highlands you met in episode one as the source of the Dordogne's rivers. Between them runs a low saddle of soft limestone maybe a hundred kilometers wide, connecting the Paris Basin to the Aquitaine Basin. That saddle is the *seuil*, the threshold, and it is the only easy way to walk, march, ride, or lay track between northern France and the southwest. Every road, every pilgrim route, every railway, every army for two thousand years has funneled through this gap. Your train is in the funnel right now.

And when all of history funnels through one gap, the gap collects battles the way a doorway collects draft. Two of the biggest, both within a day's walk of your track. In 732, near Tours and Poitiers, Charles Martel's Frankish line stopped the great Umayyad raid from Spain — the battle that, in the grand old schoolbook version, decided that Europe north of the Pyrenees would be Christian rather than Muslim; modern historians shrink it to a large raid repulsed, but its legend built kings, and the legend was born in this gap. And in 1356 the Black Prince — Edward, Prince of Wales, son of the English king — was caught near Poitiers at the end of one of his great mounted raids, the *chevauchées* — pronounced shuh-voh-SHAY — out of English Aquitaine. Outnumbered, he stood, and shattered the French army, and captured the King of France himself, John the Second. A king of France, taken prisoner in a field you're about to pass at three hundred kilometers an hour. The ransom demanded was so vast it broke French finances for a generation, and the war it belonged to is the same Hundred Years' War whose castles you'll stare across the river at on Sunday afternoon, and whose final cannonade ends ten kilometers from your Thursday wine stop. The raids that made the Black Prince infamous were launched from, and aimed at, precisely the country you'll spend your week in. Same war, seen twice: today from the train at the gap where a king was caught; Sunday from the ramparts where the border actually ground.

Around Poitiers, if you're on the left side, you may glimpse something that looks like a crashed spaceship farm: the Futuroscope theme park, France's 1980s bet on a technology-of-the-image amusement park, still going, still odd — IMAX domes and mirrored cubes in

the middle of goat country. Poitou is also chèvre country, and its little cylinder of chabichou — pronounced shah-bee-SHOO — is one of the great goat cheeses; if the bar car offers anything with local cheese, that's the province you'd be tasting.

Next waypoint: Angoulême — pronounced ahn-goo-LEM — which announces itself, if you catch it, as a walled old town on a dramatic ridge above the Charente river. Angoulême's modern identity: comic-book capital of France — home of the great annual comics festival and the national comics museum, the walls around town painted with murals. I enjoy that your route today runs from the caves' painted walls to a city of painted walls; France has been drawing on its buildings for twenty thousand years and sees no reason to stop.

And the Charente — pronounced shah-RONT — the slow green river below Angoulême's ridge, is your cue that you've entered spirit country, because downstream lies the town of Cognac. Since you'll be toasting at a wedding in a few days, you may as well know the two-minute science of the world's most famous brandy. Cognac starts as a thin, sharp, frankly unpleasant white wine — and that's the point: high acid and low alcohol survive distillation beautifully. It's distilled twice in onion-shaped copper pot stills — copper matters, it binds the sulfurous off-notes — and the clear spirit then sleeps in barrels of French oak for years to decades. And the detail I save for people I like: the evaporation. Around two percent of every barrel is lost to the air every year — the angels' share — *la part des anges*, lah par day-ZAHNZH. Multiply by a region full of warehouses and Cognac loses the equivalent of millions of bottles a year to the sky. The escaping alcohol feeds a black fungus — *Baudoinia*, boh-DWAN-ee-ah — that stains the town's rooftops and walls sooty dark — you can see where the angels have been drinking. The tax authorities of the eighteenth century learned to spot hidden stills by the blackened walls; the fungus was the informer.

Somewhere in this stretch, glance at the window frame itself and appreciate what you're not feeling. You're crossing river valleys on kilometer-long viaducts and passing under hills in cuttings deep enough to bury a cathedral. The Sud Europe Atlantique line has hundreds of engineered structures; the crossing of the Dordogne itself, east of Bordeaux, is one of the longest viaducts on the line. The train doesn't slow for any of it. Great infrastructure works by making itself unnoticeable — the better the engineering, the less there is to feel — which makes it the exact opposite of a medieval castle, whose entire job was to be felt from ten kilometers away. You'll get to compare directly tomorrow.

After Angoulême the land relaxes, softens, and starts rehearsing the south: the first parasol pines, walls going whitewashed, roofs flattening toward terracotta, and then — vines. When rows of vines start ribboning past in earnest, you've crossed into the Gironde — pronounced zhee-ROND — the department of Bordeaux, named for the great funnel estuary where your destination city sits. And in mid-September, look closely at those vines, because you may catch the vendange — pronounced vahn-DAHNZH — the grape harvest, the one week of the year when the vineyards are full of people, trailers, and crates. Harvest dates here typically run from mid-September for the merlot; your timing is close to perfect. If you see picking crews from the train today, remember them Thursday in Saint-Émilion, where I'll explain — in that episode — exactly why the merlot comes off the vine first and what the limestone under the town has to do with your glass.

While the Charente country rolls by, two more things about this machine and this line, because they complete the picture.

First, the human system. You're likely riding an Océane trainset — the double-decker generation introduced for this line's 2017 opening; if you're on the upper deck, you're sitting roughly four meters off the rails doing three hundred plus, which is worth savoring for a second. Up front, the driver is doing something counterintuitive: at this speed, human eyes are useless for reading signals beside the track — at eighty-three meters a second, a trackside sign is gone before it registers. So on the high-speed line there are no signals to see; the signaling comes to the driver, displayed in the cab, transmitted through the rails themselves, with the permitted speed continuously shown and automatically enforced. The driver's job at cruise is monitoring, anticipation, and energy management — knowing the line's every rise and dip and letting momentum do the work, surfing a four-hundred-tonne train on gravity between power notches. It's closer to piloting than driving, and France treats it accordingly.

Second, the deep view out the window. Since the first plane episode you've known that France is mostly vanished seas — this is the version you can watch at speed. This whole run from the Loire to Bordeaux is one long slide across sedimentary country: chalk and soft limestone through Poitou — the same broad family of rock, of similar marine vintage, as the cliffs waiting for you in the Périgord; then younger and younger cover as you drop southwest into the Aquitaine Basin proper, until around Bordeaux you're on gravels the rivers dumped practically yesterday, geologically speaking — and river gravels, drained and sun-warmed, are precisely what some of the region's most famous vineyards grow on. The sequence out your window — old chalk to young gravel — is the same staircase you'll climb in reverse on Sunday, driving east and backward in time into older stone and older stories. France arranged its geology very considerably for narrative purposes.

And a small ritual to watch for: the moment another TGV passes the opposite way. Closing speed, around six hundred kilometers an hour; the whole event — twelve carriages of it — lasts about a second and hits your window like a soft punch of air. The nineteenth century would have called it impossible; on board, it barely registers.

Then the line bends west, joins the old railway, and does something trains have done since 1860: it crosses the Garonne — pronounced gah-RON — into Bordeaux on the alignment of the Passerelle Eiffel. The original iron bridge here was an early triumph of a twenty-something engineer named Gustave Eiffel — five hundred meters of iron lattice on deep-sunk piers, the project that helped make his name a decade before the tower made it immortal. The modern crossing beside it carries you into the great arched trainshed of Gare Saint-Jean — pronounced gar san-ZHAHN — whose vast iron-and-glass hall, from the same golden age of railway confidence, has just one instruction attached: as you get off, look up.

And since the city at the end of this line is the world's most famous wine name, you should land knowing the wine story in miniature — the left-bank half; Saint-Émilion, the right bank, gets its own episode on Thursday.

Why here at all? Because Bordeaux is a port first and a vineyard second. The estuary gave the wine a door to the sea, and the customer walked through it in 1152 — you know her: Eleanor. The moment Aquitaine married England, Bordeaux became England's wine cellar, and for three centuries the autumn wine fleet — hundreds of ships — carried the young light red the English called claret. England drank Bordeaux for so long and so faithfully that the taste outlived the political marriage by five centuries and counting. Then, in the sixteen hundreds, Dutch engineers — the other great hydraulic people — drained the marshes north of the city, exposing those warm gravel banks I mentioned, and the grand estates of the Médoc planted onto them. By 1855, when Napoleon the Third wanted a ranking of the best estates for the Paris Exposition, the Bordeaux brokers produced in two weeks a five-tier classification of the leading châteaux — essentially a price list dressed as a league table — which promptly froze into scripture: it has been revised exactly once in a hundred and seventy years. Wine people can recite it the way sports fans recite lineups.

The science, in one glass: Bordeaux is a blending region. The two banks split the work — Cabernet Sauvignon leads on the left bank's warm gravels, which it needs to ripen its thick, tannic skins; Merlot leads on the right bank's cooler limestone and clay, where you're going Thursday. Blending is insurance and architecture: the grapes ripen at different times and shine in different vintages, so the blend smooths the weather and layers the structure — Cabernet for the tannic spine and the decades of aging, Merlot for the flesh. And the tannins that make young Bordeaux taste like licking a plank are the whole point: they're antioxidant scaffolding, and as they slowly polymerize over years in bottle they soften, drop, and leave behind the resolved, autumnal thing that made the region's name. Bordeaux is wine engineered on the TGV principle — built as a system, designed for the long run, indifferent to instant gratification. When someone at the wedding this week asks what makes Bordeaux Bordeaux, you now have a better answer than "France."

One face to attach to the city before you arrive, and he's a face you half-know already from the plane episodes: Michel de Montaigne — pronounced mon-TEN-yuh. His best friend was Étienne de La Boétie of Sarlat, the teenager who invented civil disobedience — you'll walk past his birthplace on Monday morning — and when La Boétie died young, Montaigne's grief eventually turned into the *Essays*: the book where a human being first sat down and honestly described his own mind wandering, inventing the personal essay and arguably the modern interior self, under a made-up word — *essais*, attempts. What's less known is that Montaigne wrote it all a day's ride from your route: his tower still stands on his family estate in the hills between Bordeaux and the Dordogne valley, its beams carved with his favorite quotations, and he served — twice, reluctantly, and by most accounts well — as mayor of Bordeaux, doing his civic duty through plague years and religious war while insisting the whole time that he'd rather be reading. The southwest's two great gifts to philosophy were a Sarlat teenager who said no one can rule you without your consent, and his best friend from Bordeaux who said know what your own mind is actually doing. Between the two of them they roughly bracket the operating manual for a free person, and you'll cross both their doorsteps inside twenty-four hours this week.

And one thing you won't see but should know is out there: past Bordeaux, the river becomes the Gironde estuary — the largest estuary in western Europe, the funnel through which every barrel of claret ever shipped went to sea. At its mouth, on a tidal rock, stands the Cordouan lighthouse — four hundred years old, a Renaissance palace of a lighthouse with a royal apartment and a chapel inside, still manned by keepers, the last inhabited lighthouse in France, and lately given the same UNESCO status as the caves you're about to visit. The French built a lighthouse like a palace for the same reason they built this train: a conviction that engineering done well enough becomes culture. You'll meet that conviction again on the hill above Montignac.

So: Bordeaux. You have tonight and an early night — I've seen the itinerary; you have a seven a.m. date with a rental car — so what follows is the landing briefing, city edition, calibrated for one good evening.

First, the shape of the place. Bordeaux sits on the inside of a crescent bend of the Garonne, which is why its old name is the Port de la Lune, the Port of the Moon — there's a crescent moon on the city's coat of arms. What makes the city visually astonishing — and UNESCO-listed on a nearly unmatched scale; almost half the city is protected — is its unity: mile after mile of matched eighteenth-century golden limestone, because Bordeaux had its boom in one sustained burst in the seventeen hundreds and built accordingly. One honest note before the architecture: that wealth came from Atlantic trade, and Atlantic trade in the eighteenth century meant wine and colonial sugar and coffee — and Bordeaux was also one of France's major slave-trade ports. The city has, late and imperfectly but genuinely, begun saying so out loud, with plaques and museum rooms naming what the facades were built on. It's worth knowing both truths as you walk the riverfront: it is beautiful, and it was paid for in more than wine.

For your evening, one walk assembles the whole city. Start at the Place de la Bourse, the royal square on the river — pure seventeen-thirties confidence — and cross to the miroir d'eau, the water mirror: the world's largest reflecting pool, two centimeters of water over black granite, cycling between mirror-still and knee-high fog every quarter hour. It sounds like a gimmick until dusk, when the facades double themselves in the water, swifts hunt through the fog jets, and you take the photograph that ends up framed.

Then walk the riverfront quays, glance at the Pont de Pierre — the stone bridge Napoleon ordered, with, the story goes, an arch for every letter of his name — and drift back into the old town toward dinner through the Saint-Pierre quarter's narrow streets. If you have room after dinner, find a canelé — pronounced kah-nuh-LAY — Bordeaux's own pastry: a small fluted cylinder, mahogany-dark chewy caramelized crust around a custardy rum-and-vanilla heart. Legend credits convent kitchens using up the egg yolks left over when wineries took the whites for clarifying wine — the fining process — and whether or not that's tidy history, it's good eating, and it's the correct dessert for tonight because it's made of exactly this city: wine trade, sugar trade, and gold-brown stone, in pastry form.

Logistics postscript for the morning, since I know the schedule: the Sixt office is on Cours Georges Clemenceau near Place Gambetta — an easy walk from a city-center hotel — pickup at seven, and your itinerary already flags the two truths of the morning: allow twenty minutes for paperwork, and fill the tank before leaving the city, because rural French fuel stations on a Sunday are automated card-readers that sulk at some foreign cards. Do those two things and by mid-morning you'll be standing in a market square in the Périgord holding a strawberry, at which point the short episodes take over — one per site, in order, starting with episode five as you drive in.

One last thing before I let you watch France go by. Tomorrow you drive east into the hills, and the week ahead runs like a core sample down through everything this train just crossed in two flat hours: eighteenth-century Bordeaux at the surface, medieval castles below that, the painted caves at the bottom, and a wedding — the oldest ceremony there is — running through all of it. The trip runs down the column of time as much as it runs southwest across the map, and you're making the descent in the right order, slowly, together, with very good lunches. The train is fast; the week should be slow.

See you in the car tomorrow morning. Bring the appetite, charge the phone, and remember — the market ladies get a bonjour before anything else.

END OF EPISODE 4 SCRIPT

Episode 4 pronunciation table (reference only — do not feed to TTS)

French	IPA	Respelling
Montparnasse	/mɔ̃.paʁ.nas/	mon-par-NAHSS
Gare Saint-Jean	/gaʁ sɛ̃ ʒɑ̃/	gar san-ZHAHN
train à grande vitesse	/tʁɛ̃ a ɡʁɑ̃d vi.tɛs/	tran ah grahnd vee-TESS
ligne à grande vitesse (LGV)	/liɲ a ɡʁɑ̃d vi.tɛs/	LEEN-yuh ah grahnd vee-TESS
Beauce	/bos/	BOHSS
Loire	/lwaʁ/	LWAR
Tours	/tuʁ/	TOOR
Amboise	/ɑ̃.bwaz/	ahm-BWAHZ
seuil du Poitou	/sœj dy pwa.tu/	SUY dew pwah-TOO
Poitiers	/pwa.tje/	pwah-TYAY
chevauchée	/ʃə.vo.ʃe/	shuh-voh-SHAY
chabichou	/ʃa.bi.ʃu/	shah-bee-SHOO
Angoulême	/ɑ̃.gu.lɛm/	ahn-goo-LEM
Charente	/ʃa.ʁɑ̃t/	shah-RONT
la part des anges	/la paʁ de.zɑ̃ʒ/	lah PAR day-ZAHNZH
Gironde	/ʒi.ʁɔ̃d/	zhee-ROND
vendange	/vɑ̃.dɑ̃ʒ/	vahn-DAHNZH
Garonne	/ga.ʁɔn/	gah-RON
Passerelle Eiffel	/pas.ʁɛl ɛ.fɛl/	pass-REL ay-FELL
Port de la Lune	/pɔʁ də la lyn/	POR duh lah LEWN
Place de la Bourse	/plas də la buʁs/	PLAHSS duh lah BOORSS
miroir d'eau	/mi.ʁwaʁ do/	meer-WAHR DOH
Pont de Pierre	/pɔ̃ də pjɛʁ/	PON duh PYAIR
canelé	/kan.le/	kah-nuh-LAY
Cours Georges Clemenceau	/kuʁ ʒɔʁʒ kle.mɑ̃.so/	KOOR ZHORZH klay-mahn-SOH

THE SITE WARM-UPS

Short episodes, in trip order. Each one is sized to play in the car on the approach, or in the queue. Format: a little context, what to look for, and the dos and don'ts, all inside the script so you don't have to read anything.

Episode 5 — Saint-Cyprien Market

Sunday ~09:30, playing as you come down into the valley. ~5 min.

SCRIPT

Good morning, you two. If this is playing on schedule, you've survived the Sixt paperwork, the tank is full — it is full, right? — and you're dropping out of the hills into the Dordogne valley for the first time. First stop: groceries. The Sunday market at Saint-Cyprien — pronounced san-see-pree-AN — comes before any castle or cave because the weekly market is the region's oldest living institution, and an hour in one does more to land you in a place than any monument.

Saint-Cyprien is a working town, and its market is better for it. It grew up around a big abbey; you'll see the heavy church tower above the rooftops, more fortress than steeple, which in this region, after episode three, should read as entirely reasonable. The market takes over the main street and squares from nine until about one, and it's the real weekly shop for the surrounding villages: locals with baskets, farmers who milked at dawn, and the full September table.

Practicalities first, because they bite. The streets close from six a.m. — park outside the barriers, on the edge of town, and walk in; don't go looking for a closer spot, there isn't one. Bring cash in small bills. And rehearse the ritual once more: bonjour to the stallholder before anything else, point rather than touch — the seller picks the produce, that's their craft — and merci beaucoup on the way out. Those three moves are the whole password.

What should be on the tables in mid-September: figs, the late strawberries, plums, the first fresh walnuts of the harvest — and, if it rained in the last two weeks, cèpes, the great brown porcini of episode three, piled high. There will be walnut bread, walnut oil, and little discs of Cabécou — pronounced kah-bay-KOO — the local soft goat cheese; buy one ripe and one firm and compare. There will be roast chickens turning on a spit, smelling illegal. There will also be jars saying truffle in September — you know the truth about those; smile and keep walking.

Your mission is a picnic-adjacent haul: fruit, cheese, maybe saucisson, walnut bread — things that survive a warm car for a couple of hours, since lunch today is a proper sit-down near La Roque-Gageac and dinner is spoken for in Sarlat. Buy small. Taste what's offered. And take ten minutes to watch the theater of it — the regulars, the banter, the gravity of a French person selecting one melon. This is the region's parliament, and it's been in session, weekly, in towns like this since the bastide charters seven hundred years ago.

One more thing while you're walking: notice the golden limestone in ordinary use, holding up a butcher's shop instead of a monument. And pace yourselves. The valley has been here a hundred million years; it will still be there after the cheese.

Next stop when you're back in the car: a village that decided the best place to build was inside a cliff.

END OF EPISODE 5 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Saint-Cyprien	/sɛ̃ si.pʁi.ɛ̃/	san-see-pree-AN
Cabécou	/ka.be.ku/	kah-bay-KOO
saucisson	/so.si.sɔ̃/	soh-see-SON
cèpe	/sɛp/	SEP

Episode 6 — La Roque-Gageac, the Village in the Cliff

Sunday ~11:15, on the 25-minute drive from the market. ~5 min.

SCRIPT

You're now driving one of the great short river roads of Europe, and the thing you're about to see tends to make drivers stop paying attention, so whoever isn't driving is on scenery duty.

La Roque-Gageac — pronounced lah ROCK gah-ZHACK — is a single line of golden houses pressed between the Dordogne river and a hundred-meter overhanging cliff, facing due south across the water. It's officially listed among the most beautiful villages in France, and it's one of the few places on the list that actually under-promises. The whole village is maybe one street deep. There was nowhere else to build. They built anyway, for about a thousand years.

The site works because of everything in episode one, cashed in at once. The cliff is a south-facing limestone wall, so the village sits in a natural solar oven — the rock drinks sun all day and radiates it back all night. The microclimate is so gentle that halfway along the lane you'll walk into a little exotic garden — palms, bananas, bamboo, oleander — planted by a local enthusiast in the twentieth century and thriving, absurdly, at the same latitude as Newfoundland. And high up in the cliff face, look for the doorways and galleries cut into the bare rock: the troglodyte fort, a defensive refuge carved in the middle ages, reachable then only by ladders that could be pulled up behind you. Vikings, English routiers, Protestant armies — the threat changed costume every century; the answer stayed the same: go up the wall. People sheltering in this exact limestone is a habit fifty-five thousand years old around here; this village is the habit's most photogenic recent chapter.

The river itself is the other half of the story. Before rail, the Dordogne was the highway, and La Roque-Gageac was a port. The flat-bottomed wooden boats you'll see on the water — gabarres, pronounced gah-BAR — are modern tourist rebuilds of the barges that ran oak timber, walnut oil, and wine down to Bordeaux. The economics were brutally one-way: the current took you down in days, but coming back up meant teams of men and oxen hauling from the bank — so many gabarres were sold in Bordeaux as lumber along with the cargo, and the crews walked home. Imagine the state of their shoes.

Your plan is forty-five minutes on foot, and it's the right amount: the river path for the postcard view, then the narrow lanes that stair-step up between the houses, find the exotic garden, look up at the fort. Skip the boat ride: the village is the thing to see, and you see it from the land — from the boat you mostly see other boats. Two footnotes as you walk. One: the cliff gives as well as takes — in 1957 a slab peeled off the overhang and destroyed several houses, killing three people; the scar is still visible, and it's why some upper galleries are closed. Respect any barriers — the cliff is still moving, on geological time.

Two: hold the thought of that one-street, cliff-backed layout — in about three hours, from the ramparts at Beynac, you’ll see this whole village again from above, the size of a bracelet on the riverbank, and it may be its best angle.

Then lunch. You’ve earned the terrace. Order something with cèpes if the blackboard offers it — you know why.

END OF EPISODE 6 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
La Roque-Gageac	/la ʁɔk ga.ʒak/	lah ROCK gah-ZHACK
gabarre	/ga.baʁ/	gah-BAR
troglodyte	/tʁɔɡlɔ.dit/	tro-glo-DEET

Episode 7 — The Hanging Gardens of Marqueyssac

Sunday ~13:50, the short hop after lunch. ~5 min.

SCRIPT

Five minutes up the road, and you're swapping raw geology for geology in a tuxedo. The Jardins de Marqueyssac — pronounced mar-kay-SACK — are the gardens of a small seventeenth-century château on a spur of rock a hundred and thirty meters above the river, and they hold the single best viewpoint over everything you've seen and are about to see today. But the reason to come is stranger than a view: a hundred and fifty thousand boxwood trees, clipped by hand into a rolling sea of green domes, and the story of one man's fixation.

The short history: the estate is old, but the garden as you'll see it is the work of Julien de Cerval, a gentleman who inherited it in the eighteen-sixties after soldiering in Italy, where he'd fallen in love with Italian gardens and, apparently, with boxwood specifically. He spent thirty years planting and clipping his clifftop into something between a garden and a hallucination: soft, bulbous, cloud-like masses rippling away over the ridge, about as far from the rigid geometry of Versailles as clipped plants can get. After a century of neglect, the whole thing was restored in the nineteen-nineties and reopened in 1997, and today a small team of gardeners still clips every dome by hand, twice a year, with electric shears and long patience. The hill settles any argument about whether topiary counts as an art.

Why boxwood, if you want the botany: box is slow, dense, and shade-tolerant, with tiny leaves that regrow from old wood — meaning it takes a haircut like no other plant and holds the shape for months. Also — you'll notice within a minute — it has a smell: warm, musky, catty, entirely distinctive. People either love it or wrinkle their noses. Either way it's the official smell of aristocratic patience, and you'll carry it out on your clothes. A darker botanical footnote: across Europe, box is being eaten alive by an invasive Asian moth, and gardens like this one now fight a permanent quiet war of traps and treatments to keep a hundred and fifty thousand trees alive. The serenity is defended.

Now, your marching orders, because one tip matters more than the rest: do not stop at the main belvedere. The crowds pool at the first great viewpoint near the château; the path along the cliff keeps going, and it keeps getting better — quieter, wilder, along the smaller rustic paths, until you reach the far belvedere hanging directly over the river. From up there, the whole morning assembles itself like a map: La Roque-Gageac directly below, a line of gold on the green water; Castelnaud — the English castle — on its hill; the river doing its huge lazy meanders; and across the valley, the fortress you're storming next: Beynac. This terrace is the best place in the Périgord to see the Hundred Years' War as geography — every castle in sight was once a piece on this exact board, in sight of its enemies, because sight was the point.

Housekeeping: it’s a two-hour visit at your pace, the paths are proper gravel-and-root walking so the good shoes matter, there’s an electric shuttle if feet rebel, and there are peacocks, who own the place and know it. The tearoom is decent if lunch was light. And keep one eye on the clock — your only hard gate today is Beynac’s last entry at six, and Marqueyssac is the accordion in the plan: it compresses gracefully. The far belvedere first, then wander back; that way if time runs short, you’ve already banked the best of it.

END OF EPISODE 7 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Marqueyssac	/maʁ.kɛ.sak/	mar-kay-SACK
Julien de Cerval	/ʒy.ljɛ̃ də sɛʁ.val/	zhoo-LYAN duh sair-VALL
belvédère	/bɛl.ve.dɛʁ/	bel-vay-DAIR
allée	/a.le/	ah-LAY
Castelnaud	/kas.tɛl.no/	kass-tel-NOH

Episode 8 — Beynac, the Angry Castle

Sunday ~16:05, the ten-minute hop. ~4 min.

SCRIPT

Ten minutes, one river bend, and seven hundred years of attitude. Château de Beynac — pronounced bay-NACK — is the fortress you’ve been looking at from Marqueyssac, and up close it drops all pretense: a twelfth-century keep with walls up to two meters thick, a hundred and fifty meters of cliff under its feet, seat of one of the four great baronies of the old Périgord — families who answered to nobody local at all.

Quick logistics while you park, because today’s only hard gate lives here: last access is at six o’clock, park at the base and walk up — the climb is steep, cobbled, and honest, and it’s also the point: every visitor for eight hundred years arrived winded, which is how the castle liked them. The commentary runs on your own phone, collected at reception — so charge the phone in the car on the way over, and use your earbuds; half the documented complaints about this place are other people’s speakerphones echoing off medieval stone. Some things the middle ages never had to deal with.

Its history, briefly: Richard the Lionheart’s forces took and held this castle for a stretch in the eleven-nineties, during his years of stomping the Périgord into obedience. Then, for the long century of the Hundred Years’ War, Beynac stood French while Castelnau, across the water, stood English — the two glaring at each other over a kilometer of river, trading raids and spies for generations. The river between them was, functionally, the border between two crowns. Sunday-afternoon peace has hung over this valley for so long now that it takes work to see it as a militarized frontier — the work is what the ramparts are for.

What to look for inside. The great hall where the barons of the Périgord met is moving in its plainness — power in this century was a big fireplace, a big table, and the right to make others travel to you. Find the kitchen with its vast hearths. And save your time for the ramparts, because that’s the payoff: the whole valley at your feet, La Roque-Gageac a gold thread below, Marqueyssac’s green cliff opposite, and Castelnau in plain, deliberate, insolent view. Stand there and run yesterday’s train logic in reverse: where the TGV works by going unnoticed, the castle worked by being seen — by slowing everything down and making every boat and cart below feel watched. That held for four hundred years, until the Bureau brothers’ cannon turned two-meter walls into two-meter targets.

One modern footnote: the film industry can’t leave Beynac alone — it’s played medieval France for Luc Besson’s Joan of Arc among others, and the village below has stood in for the fifteenth century so often that some residents have been extras more than once. When you walk back down through it, you’ll see why nobody has to build sets here.

Down by five-fifty, in the car, and twenty minutes to Domme for the evening light. The hard part of the day is done; what’s left is dessert.

END OF EPISODE 8 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Beynac	/bɛ.nak/	bay-NACK
Castelnaud	/kas.tɛl.no/	kass-tel-NOH
Richard Cœur de Lion	/ʁi.ʃaʁ kœʁ də ljɔ̃/	ree-SHAR kur-duh-LYON

Episode 9 — Domme in the Evening Light

Sunday ~17:55, driving up the hill. ~4 min.

SCRIPT

Last climb of the day, and this one the car does for you. Domme — DOM, one syllable, like the first half of dominant — is a fortified hilltop town four hundred feet above the river, and you're arriving at the best hour of its day: the light going long and gold, the coaches gone, the stone warming up for its evening glow.

Domme is a bastide — one of those planned new towns from episode three — founded in 1281 by the French crown as a border stronghold against English country downriver. As you walk in through the gate, clock the street plan: it wants to be a perfect grid, and mostly is, except where the cliff top refused — the surveyor's thirteenth-century idealism negotiating with geology, and geology, as usual around here, holding the better cards. The arcaded market square at the center is the standard bastide equipment: commerce was the engine of these towns, war merely the occasion.

Two stories to carry up the hill. First, the Templars: after the king of France destroyed the order in the dawn raids of 1307, dozens of captured knights spent years imprisoned in Domme's gate towers — the Porte des Tours, which still stands, and you'll pass it — and they covered the walls with carved graffiti: crosses, grails, geometric prayers, the last testimony of men waiting for a trial rigged from the start. Access to the graffiti is limited and tour-dependent, but even from outside, it changes the tower from scenery into evidence. Second, the cave: because this is the Périgord and there is always a cave — directly beneath the market square runs a large natural cavern, entered from the middle of town, where townspeople sheltered during the wars. A planned town above, a hiding place beneath — the Périgord kept making this same move for fifty thousand years.

But the real reason you're here is the edge. Walk north from the square about two minutes and the town ends at the Belvédère de la Barre: four hundred feet of air off the edge, and the finest single panorama of the Dordogne valley below you — the river in its meanders, Beynac and La Roque-Gageac tucked into the middle distance, the whole day laid out below for review. One honest note: your itinerary calls this golden hour, and the light at six-fifteen will indeed be lovely — low, warm, coming down the valley lengthwise. But true golden hour tonight is closer to seven-thirty, with sunset just after eight. So here's your one decision of the evening: the plan says thirty minutes, ice cream, and down to Sarlat for check-in and dinner at eight, which works. But if you two hit that belvedere and something in you says stay — the dinner booking has a phone number and Sarlat is twenty-five minutes away. I mention it once, and I'll never speak of it again: you're on the best cliff in the valley, at the golden edge of a wedding week, and nobody ever regretted watching one entire sunset in the Périgord. The duck can wait half an hour.

Either way: get the ice cream on the square, mind your feet on the steep cobbles coming down, and when you finally roll into Sarlat tonight, you'll have done, in one day, a hundred million years of limestone, a market, a cliff village, a hanging garden, a war machine, and a sunset. Tomorrow, the Ice Age. Sleep like the rocks.

END OF EPISODE 9 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Domme	/dɔ̃m/	DOM
Porte des Tours	/pɔʁt de tuʁ/	PORT day TOOR
Belvédère de la Barre	/bɛl.ve.dɛʁ də la baʁ/	bel-vay-DAIR duh lah BAR
Sarlat	/saʁ.la/	sar-LAH

Episode 10 — Sarlat Before It Wakes

Monday ~08:00, over coffee before the old-town walk. ~5 min.

SCRIPT

Good morning. You have the best hour of the day in the best-preserved medieval town in France, and most of it is still asleep. This is what you're walking through, and how it nearly didn't survive.

Sarlat-la-Canéda — pronounced sar-LAH lah kah-nay-DAH — has, by the standard boast, one of the highest densities of protected historic buildings of any town on earth: sixty-some listed monuments in a few hectares of honey-colored lanes. You learned the first half of the reason on the plane: it boomed on abbey, market, and law courts, rebuilt beautifully after its wars, and then went economically obsolete — too far from the railways and the money — and spent two centuries too poor to knock anything down.

The second half of the reason has a name and a date: André Malraux, 1962 — the same culture minister who closed Lascaux the following year. His loi Malraux invented the idea of protecting whole historic districts rather than single monuments, and Sarlat was the law's first laboratory. Instead of museum-freezing the town, the restoration kept people living in it — which is why this morning you'll see actual residents taking out actual bins through fourteenth-century doorways. The law wanted the town lived-in rather than embalmed, and at eight a.m. you're seeing that at its most honest: shutters opening, bakery smell, delivery vans negotiating streets sized for handcarts.

A route for your hour, no map needed, the town is small enough to un-lose yourself in minutes. Start in the Place de la Liberté, the long central square — film crews adore it; it has stood in for old Paris more than once. Duck behind the cathedral to find the strangest structure in town: the Lanterne des Morts — pronounced lahn-TAIRN day MOR, the Lantern of the Dead — a twelfth-century stone rocket, a conical tower whose true purpose nobody has ever established. Funerary chapel, plague memorial, beacon commemorating Saint Bernard's visit in 1147 — the theories multiply precisely because the building refuses to explain itself; it's the town's own shaft scene, a masterpiece of not telling. Then find the Maison de La Boétie opposite the cathedral front — the ornate Renaissance house where Étienne de La Boétie, the teenager who invented civil disobedience and Montaigne's other half, was born in 1530. Give it the two minutes it deserves; you know his story from the plane. And pass through the Place du Marché aux Oies — the goose market square, with its bronze trio of geese — the one spot where the town's whole food economy is cast in metal and, on market days for centuries, was audible several streets away.

Last stop before the car, if the door is open at that hour: the church of Sainte-Marie, deconsecrated centuries ago, now the covered market — behind monumental modern doors of raw steel, twelve meters tall, designed by Jean Nouvel, France's most famous living architect, who grew up partly in Sarlat. Medieval nave, brutalist doors, cheese inside. There's even a panoramic glass lift up the old bell tower if it's running early.

Then: coffee down, bags down by nine-fifteen, because today is the deep-time day and it has the trip’s one truly unforgiving gate at Lascaux. On the drive to Les Eyzies, cue the next episode — it’s about why the museum comes first today.

END OF EPISODE 10 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Sarlat-la-Canéda	/saʁ.la la ka.ne.da/	sar-LAH lah kah-nay-DAH
Place de la Liberté	/plas də la li.bɛʁ.te/	PLAHSS duh lah lee-bair-TAY
Lanterne des Morts	/lɑ̃.tɛʁn də mɔʁ/	lahn-TAIRN day MOR
Maison de La Boétie	/mɛ.zɔ̃ də la bo.e.si/	may-ZON duh lah bo-ay-SEE
Place du Marché aux Oies	/plas dy maʁʃe o.z_wa/	PLAHSS dew mar-SHAY oh-ZWAH
Sainte-Marie	/sɛ̃t ma.ʁi/	sant-mah-REE
Jean Nouvel	/ʒɑ̃ nu.vɛl/	ZHAHN noo-VELL

Episode 11 — The Decoder Ring: Musée national de Préhistoire

Monday ~09:20, on the D47 to Les Eyzies. ~5 min.

SCRIPT

Twenty-five minutes of twisty road, and you're crossing a watershed in both senses: out of the Dordogne valley and into the Vézère — out of castle country and into deep time. The village at the end of this road, Les Eyzies — pronounced layz-ay-ZEE — calls itself the world capital of prehistory, and for once the tourist-office slogan is accurate: within a few kilometers of its one main street lie the type sites that named half the chapters of the human story — Cro-Magnon itself included, the rock shelter behind the hotel, found by railway workers in 1868.

You're starting at the Musée national de Préhistoire, and the logic deserves spelling out: your Lascaux visit this afternoon is self-guided. No human guide, just an audioguide and your own eyes. Which means everything you put into your head this morning becomes visible this afternoon. The museum is the decoder ring; the cave is the message. Most visitors do it backwards or skip the museum entirely, then stand in front of the greatest art of the Ice Age able to say only "wow." You two are going in armed.

The museum itself makes a statement before you even enter: it's built into the cliff, inside and around a ruined medieval castle, under a rock overhang that was itself a prehistoric shelter — a museum of the cliff, in the cliff. Standing guard on the terrace is a famous 1931 statue of a hulking, jut-browed primitive man — a monument, at this point, mostly to how wrong 1931 was about Neanderthals; consider it the "before" picture, then go inside for the "after."

With your hour forty-five, the priorities run like this. First, the stone tools, arranged in sequence — watch technique evolve over three hundred thousand years from hand axes to blades so fine they're practically cutlery; this is the deepest technological archive on the planet, most of it dug within walking distance of where you're standing.

Second, the people — the museum holds actual Neanderthal remains, including the skeleton of the Le Moustier adolescent, and the burial of a La Ferrassie child; be a fellow person about it, as discussed.

Third, the part I most don't want you to miss: the portable art. The engraved bones and carved spear-throwers of the Magdalenians, the same culture whose wall paintings you'll see today and tomorrow. Look for the carved bison turning its head to lick its flank, from La Madeleine — a piece of such economy and observation that it belongs in any museum of any century. The wall art stayed in the caves; this is the art they carried in their pockets, and it shows the paintings as the visible edge of a culture soaked in image-making, rather than a special-occasion skill.

Last, find the third-floor terrace, look down the Vézère — cliffs, river, meadows — and fix the view, because that’s the landscape every object in the building came out of, and if the morning mist is still burning off the river, you’re seeing it in period costume.

Logistics, quickly: park free by Pâtisserie Margot; museum’s six euros, no booking; and it’s closed Tuesdays, which is why it had to be today. At eleven forty-five, bakery: buy lunch to carry — sit-down lunch is impossible today, kitchens here open exactly when you need to be driving — and if Margot’s shutters turn out to be down — French bakeries do close on Mondays — Montignac has two good bakeries within a kilometer of Lascaux, so buy there instead. Either way, eat before Lascaux, because bags don’t go in. Then north up the valley to Montignac, past walnut groves and under cliffs with doors in them. Play the next episode on that drive. It’s the big one.

END OF EPISODE 11 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Les Eyzies	/le.z_ε.zi/	layz-ay-ZEE
Musée national de Préhistoire	/my.ze na.sjɔ.nal də pʁe.is.twæ/	mew-ZAY nah-syo-NALL duh pray-ees- TWAR
Le Moustier	/lə mus.tje/	luh moo-STYAY
La Ferrassie	/la fɛ.ʁa.si/	lah fair-ah-SEE
La Madeleine	/la mad.lɛn/	lah mad-LEN
Pâtisserie Margot	/pa.tis.ʁi maʁ.go/	pah-teess-REE mar-GOH
Montignac	/mɔ̃.ti.ɲak/	mon-teen-YACK

Episode 12 — Lascaux IV

Monday ~12:00, on the drive to Montignac. ~6 min.

SCRIPT

This is the one the whole day is built around. Checklist first, then the rest.

Checklist: be at the doors by twelve-thirty — your slot is twelve-fifty and the ticket's language about late arrivals is not bluffing. Backpacks stay in the car, all sizes, no exceptions, so pockets only: phone, tickets on the wallet pass, and both jackets, because the whole building runs cave-cold at sixteen degrees and you'll be inside for the better part of two and a half hours. Eat the bakery lunch in the car park before you go in. That's the whole list.

Now the cave. You know the discovery story from the plane — Ravidat, Marsal, the dog, the fallen pine, September 1940. You know why the real cave is sealed on the hill above you, and why what you're entering is a millimeter-faithful rebuild, painted by living artists with Ice Age pigments on sculpted rock. What's left to add on the doorstep is how to visit it well, in the format you've got.

Your format — self-guided, audioguide, no group — is the best one this site offers, because the two historic complaints about Lascaux four were herded groups and forced pace, and you have neither. Use that. The reconstruction begins, as the cave does, with the Hall of the Bulls, and the correct behavior there is to stop. Let the group behind you flow past. Stand in the middle. Look up and turn around slowly, because the hall works as a single composition — seventeen thousand years ago somebody thought about how a torch-carrying viewer would move through it, and the animals wheel around you in a deliberate cavalcade: the four great black bulls — one over five meters, the largest figure in all cave art — the red horses running through them, the strange spotted so-called unicorn leading the parade inward.

Find at least one place where a bull and a horse are painted over each other in obviously different styles: the room was repainted and added to across generations, possibly across centuries, and the overlaps are where you can watch them answering each other.

Then the Axial Gallery, the so-called Sistine ceiling — the falling horse at the far end, upside down, wrapped around a rock the painter had to reach by scaffold; the swimming stags, five heads crossing a river the artist made out of a natural ledge. Notice, over and over, the trick the museum primed you for this morning: the rock's own bulges and cracks doing half the anatomy, the animal summoned out of the stone rather than applied to it. And at the end, in the reconstructed shaft section, you'll meet the one human in the whole cave: the bird-headed man, falling before the gutted bison, beside the bird on the pole. The audioguide will offer theories politely. Twenty thousand years of hypotheses stand in front of that scene like visitors, and it outlasts them all. Give it your own minute of silence and your own guess; yours is as admissible as anyone's.

Practical grace notes. The lighting is deliberately dim and torch-like — give your eyes a full minute to adjust in each chamber and the colors will bloom; hurrying visitors never see the cave at full saturation. The cold matches the real cave, on purpose. And when you exit into the post-cave galleries — the workshop, the theater of wall art, the immersive rooms — your itinerary already says don’t skip them, and I’ll second it with a reason: the workshop, especially, is where the replica confesses how it was made — scans, pigments, artists’ benches — and after what you’ve just seen, watching humans of your own century laboring to copy humans of the Ice Age, faithfully, at ruinous expense, for no reason except love and memory, is in its own way as moving as the bulls. It’s the same impulse, pointed backward.

You’ll surface around three-twenty, blinking, in the wrong century. The café is skippable, per your notes and everyone else’s. Water, a stretch, and then — if legs and spirits hold — twenty-five minutes south to a kilometer of cliff where this valley’s whole fifty-five-thousand-year lease is stacked in plain sight. If instead you look at each other and say home, that’s allowed too — La Roque Saint-Christophe was always the day’s optional piece. Next episode either way; it’s short, like the visit.

END OF EPISODE 12 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Lascaux	/las.ko/	lass-KOH
Montignac	/mɔ̃.ti.nak/	mon-teen-YACK
Salle des Taureaux (Hall of the Bulls)	/sal de to.ʁo/	SALL day toh-ROH
Diverticule axial (Axial Gallery)	/di.vɛʁ.ti.kyl ak.sjal/	dee-vair-tee-KEWL ak-SYALL

Episode 13 — The Vertical City: La Roque Saint-Christophe

Monday ~15:25, the short drive south. ~4 min.

SCRIPT

Short drive, short episode, and a promise: this site asks nothing of your brain after Lascaux. It's a cliff a kilometer long and eighty meters high, gnawed into five stories of natural terraces, where people lived for fifty-five thousand years. You walk along a shelf in the sky and look at the river. After the morning you've had, that's the right kind of visit.

La Roque Saint-Christophe — pronounced lah ROCK san-kree-STOFF — is the largest rock shelter complex in Europe, and it's the place where the whole architecture lesson from the plane stands up and performs. Remember the abri — the overhang formed where frost and river pried out the soft limestone beds and left the hard beds as roofs? Here that process ran a kilometer wide. At the bottom of the cliff, and in the ground below it, are the Neanderthal layers — Mousterian tools, fifty-five thousand years old, from the culture named at Le Moustier, the hamlet at the foot of this rock; you drove past its sign. At the top, a medieval town: from the tenth century, when the fort was first raised to watch for Viking longships coming up the Vézère — yes, really, Vikings, this far inland — through the Hundred Years' War, when it sheltered hundreds of people, a market, workshops, a chapel, all bolted to the terraces. Look for the square sockets and beam slots cut everywhere in the rock: entire timber houses hung off this wall, and the holes are their fossils. Same cliff, same logic, fifty-five millennia apart: when the world turns dangerous, go up the limestone and pull the ladder.

The end of the story you already know from the plane: 1588, Wars of Religion, the fortress had sheltered Protestants, and the king's men razed it — one order ending the longest continuous tenancy in Europe. What's left is the stone skeleton, plus the museum's full-size reconstructions of the medieval machines — the winches, treadwheel cranes and capstans they used to hoist everything from firewood to building beams up the face. Human-powered engineering at its most satisfying. One of you is going to lose ten minutes at the treadwheel, and you both already know which one.

Two tips. First, take the free guided tour if one's running — a good guide turns rock holes back into a city. If your timing misses it, the walkway signage is decent and your legs set the pace. Second, this is the day's gentlest schedule: last admission five-thirty, you're arriving before four, so there's no clock pressure at all — the first time today that's been true. Let the shoulders down accordingly.

And when you're done, it's fifty-five minutes north to Essendières, out of the Black Périgord and into the green — softer hills, pasture, apples. You'll unpack once and stay unpacked till Thursday. Somebody's getting married. Play the next episode on that drive if you've got the appetite, or save it for Wednesday coffee — it's about the estate you're sleeping on, and it contains, improbably, Marcel Proust.

END OF EPISODE 13 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
La Roque Saint-Christophe	/la ʁɔk sɛ̃ kʁis.tɔf/	lah ROCK san-kree-STOFF
Peyzac-le-Moustier	/pɛ.zak lə mus.tje/	pay-ZACK luh moo-STYAY
Vézère	/ve.zɛʁ/	vay-ZAIR

Episode 14 — Essendiéras, Proust, and the Green Périgord

Monday evening on the drive north, or Wednesday morning with coffee. ~4 min.

SCRIPT

This one's a bonus track — no tickets, no gates, no shoes advice. It's about where you're staying, because the estate hosting this wedding has a better literary pedigree than almost any hotel in France, and hardly anyone who sleeps there knows it.

You've crossed into the Périgord Vert — the green Périgord, the region's fourth color: chestnut woods, dairy pasture, slow rivers, and a fraction of the tourists to the south. The Domaine d'Essendiéras — pronounced eh-sahn-dyay-RAHSS — is a big old estate near Excideuil: two châteaux, one seventeenth-century and one nineteenth, set in orchards, because this corner of the Périgord is apple country — the estate has been at various times one of the largest apple producers in France, and if you walk the grounds you'll walk between fruiting rows; in mid-September the trees will be heavy, close to picking. A Dutch family bought the place in the two-thousands and turned it into the resort you're staying at — golf holes among the apples, weddings in the château. Fine. But rewind a century.

For decades, Essendiéras belonged to the family of Simone de Caillavet, who became the wife of André Maurois — one of the most successful French writers of the twentieth century, biographer of Shelley, Hugo, and Proust, member of the Académie française. Maurois summered and wrote here; some of his books were written on this property. But it's the women who make the story sing. Simone's grandmother, Léontine Arman de Caillavet, ran the great Paris literary salon of the Belle Époque and was the muse — and more — of the novelist Anatole France. Her daughter-in-law, Simone's mother Jeanne, was a close youthful friend of an awkward, watchful young man named Marcel Proust — and is generally counted among the models for Gilberte, the great first love of the narrator in *In Search of Lost Time*. Proust corresponded with the family for years; their world — the salons, the hawthorn lanes, the girls at play the narrator can't stop watching — is the world his novel embalmed in the most famous act of memory in literature.

Which gives you this, and I offer it as a wedding-week thought rather than a footnote: you are sleeping, before and after a wedding, on the estate of the family that helped inspire literature's greatest book about how love and memory work — a novel arguing, across three thousand pages, that nothing lived is ever really lost, that it waits, complete, for a taste or a smell to call it back. If ever a week deserved a madeleine dipped in tea, it's this one. Failing that, an apple from the orchard, eaten slowly, will do the same job with local materials.

While you're up here: Excideuil, ten minutes away — pronounced ek-see-DOY — is the market town under a big medieval castle of the viscounts of Limoges, worth a Wednesday-morning coffee if the wedding schedule breathes; it also claims one of the great troubadours, Giraut de Bornelh, called the master of the singers — so the hill you're drinking coffee under helped invent the love song, which seems on-theme. And Hautefort,

your Monday dinner village — pronounced oat-FOR — sits under the grandest château of the region, a seventeenth-century palace more Loire than Périgord, glowing on its hilltop as you drive in. Just so you know what that silhouette was.

That’s the brief. No gates, no dos and don’ts tonight, except one: at some point this week, step out after dark. The Périgord Vert has some of the darkest rural sky in France, and mid-September at a new-moon-adjacent week is kind to stargazers. The people from Monday’s cave knew that sky by heart — same stars, give or take a proper motion. Small world, long lease.

END OF EPISODE 14 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Périgord Vert	/pe.ʁi.ɡɔʁ vɛʁ/	pay-ree-GOR VAIR
Essendiéras	/ɛ.sɑ̃.dje.ʁas/	eh-sahn-dyay-RAHSS
Excideuil	/ɛk.si.dœj/	ek-see-DOY
Hautefort	/ot.fɔʁ/	oat-FOR
André Maurois	/ɑ̃.dʁe mo.ʁwa/	ahn-DRAY mor-WAH
Arman de Caillavet	/aʁ.mɑ̃ də ka.ja.vɛ/	ar-MAHN duh kah-yah-VEH
Anatole France	/a.na.tɔl fʁɑ̃s/	ah-nah-TOLL FRAHNSS
Marcel Proust	/maʁ.sɛl pʁust/	mar-SELL PROOST
madeleine	/mad.lɛn/	mad-LEN
Giraut de Bornelh	/ʒi.ʁo də bɔʁ.nɛj/	zhee-ROH duh bor-NAY

Episode 15 — Laugerie-Basse and the Grand Roc (the optional opener)

Tuesday ~09:00, only if you took the early option. ~4 min.

SCRIPT

If this is playing, you chose the early start, and good — because this pairing is the perfect warm-up act for Font-de-Gaume, and it teaches the one distinction that makes the big cave land harder: the difference between where they lived and where they painted.

Laugerie-Basse — pronounced lozh-REE BAHSS — is a great rock shelter under the same cliff line as everything else in this valley, and it's the domestic side of the Magdalenian world: hearths, tool workshops, sewing needles, the bones of ten thousand reindeer dinners. This is a house, not a temple — a place with morning light and river view, the Ice Age equivalent of a very good apartment, occupied for thousands of years. And it's also a monument to the birth of archaeology itself, with everything that implies: it was dug from the eighteen-sixties, in the heroic and slightly horrifying pioneer era — pickaxes, haste, spoil heaps — when the science was being invented on the spot, partly right here, by men like Édouard Lartet and his English banker partner Henry Christy. The most famous find is a small carved female figure called, unimprovably, the Vénus impudique — vay-NEWSS an-pew-DEEK, the immodest Venus — the little statue that gave every prehistoric Venus figurine its name, by way of a joke about classical statuary. The original went to Paris, like most nineteenth-century finds; what stayed is the place itself, and the shelter's story is told honestly, spoil heaps and all. As you walk it, run the movie: hides on frames under the overhang, smoke, dogs, kids on the riverbank — then remember that the painted cave you'll enter at eleven-fifteen is a two-minute drive away. Same people. They lived in the light and kept something else in the dark, and nobody has ever fully explained the commute.

Next door, on the joint ticket, the Grand Roc — pronounced grahn-ROCK — flips the coin: no archaeology at all, just the limestone showing off what it does when nobody's watching. It's a small natural cave discovered in 1924, dense with crystal growth — and its specialty is the strange stuff: eccentrics — helictites, HEL-ik-tites, thin crystal tendrils that grow sideways, upward, in corkscrews, in defiance of gravity, fed by capillary seepage through pores so fine that gravity loses the vote to surface tension. Triangles, coral shapes, needle sprays: it's what pure chemistry doodles with infinite time and no deadline. After a week of asking what did the painters mean, it's restful to stand in a gallery that means nothing at all and is still beautiful. Also, practically: it's another cool one — jackets — and the balcony at its mouth has one of the best cliff-face views of the valley, worth a minute by itself.

Watch the clock with one eye — you need to be at the Font-de-Gaume ticket office by eleven, five minutes down the road, and that appointment is the one thing this week that can't be replaced. Coffee in the village if you're ahead. Next episode plays on that five-minute hop, and it's the one I'd most like you to hear twice.

END OF EPISODE 15 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Laugerie-Basse	/loʒ.ɛi bas/	lozh-REE BAHSS
Grand Roc	/ɡʁɑ̃ ʁɔk/	grahn-ROCK
Vénus impudique	/ve.nys ɛ̃.py.dik/	vay-NEWSS an-pew-DEEK
Édouard Lartet	/e.dwaʁ laʁ.te/	ay-DWAR lar-TEH

Episode 16 — Font-de-Gaume

Tuesday ~10:45, on the approach and in the queue. ~6 min.

SCRIPT

Here we are. Of everything this week, this is the hour I'd keep if I could keep only one. Checklist first, briefly, then how to see it — because seeing Font-de-Gaume well is a skill, and you can learn it in the next five minutes.

Checklist: ticket office by eleven for your eleven-fifteen slot. No bags — none, no lockers, so everything stays at the house or in the car. A layer each: fourteen degrees inside. No photos, and the approach is four hundred meters of steep path, so let the legs arrive warm. That's it.

One contingency, because the itinerary plans for it: visitor numbers here get cut for conservation, sometimes on the day itself. If your slot is among the casualties, ask right there at the desk about Combarelles — kom-bah-REL — the engraved cave a short drive up the road, run from the same office. People who have seen both rank it with anything in the valley, and on a cancelled morning you would have the time for it.

Now. What you're about to do, plainly stated: you will walk into a hill in single file with about ten other people and a guide, along a passage in places narrower than your shoulders, and you will stand in front of multi-colored paintings — bison, horses, reindeer, mammoths — made by hand, on this rock, in this dark, somewhere around fourteen thousand years ago. The paint is original. This is the last cave on earth where you can still do that with polychrome paintings — everything else of this class is sealed or was never opened. A few dozen people a day, numbers cut year over year for conservation, and no promise the door stays open another decade. Yesterday you saw a perfect copy of a lost original. Today is the original, and this is where the week's sequencing pays off.

The seeing lesson, because this is where Font-de-Gaume differs from yesterday: the art does not leap at you. Fourteen millennia of calcite film and fading have pulled some figures back into the rock, and your guide will find them for you with a flashlight, tracing an outline until — and this is the word every visitor uses — the animal suddenly assembles. Three things help it happen. First, let your eyes adapt — no phone glow in the queue, and in the cave look away from the guide's light periodically so your night vision builds. Second, when the light traces, follow the moving beam with your eyes rather than staring at the wall generally; your visual system stitches the contour and then, all at once, hands you the bison whole. It's a perceptual event — closer to developing a photograph in your own head than to viewing a picture — and once a figure has assembled for you it stays assembled, which is why the second look is always better than the first.

Third, notice the sculpting — the painters chose walls where the rock already bulged like muscle, and the polychrome shading rides the relief; tilt your head as the light moves and watch the animals go three-dimensional.

What to hope the guide shows you — routes vary with conservation, but the classics: the great frieze of bison, five of them processing along one wall. Horses and mammoths layered through the galleries — over two hundred figures in all, more than eighty of them bison. And, if you’re lucky, the scene that has become one of the most famous images of the entire Ice Age: two reindeer face to face, antlers curved around each other, the male bending to lick the forehead of the kneeling female. Fourteen thousand years old, and it is a deliberate picture of tenderness. Whatever the caves were for — magic, cosmology, memory, all of the above — someone in this hill spent hours of lamplight and hard-won pigment recording that one animal loved another. The day before your friends’ wedding, in the dark, on original stone, that’s the image you two get to stand in front of. Let it be the trip’s center of gravity.

Two last notes. Be good guests of the cave: no touching the walls, ever — skin oils are chemistry, and you know from Lascaux what visitor chemistry does; stay on the walkway, speak low, and give the guide your questions — they’re passionate, and the ones here have watched people gasp for years and still love the moment. And when you come out into the September light, don’t rush the transition; there’s a bench, and the valley below is the same valley the painters saw, minus the reindeer herds. Lunch is waiting down in the village, the afternoon is slack, and the only thing on today’s schedule after this is a welcome dinner for a wedding. You’ll walk into it carrying the licking reindeer. That’s the correct order of ceremonies.

END OF EPISODE 16 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Font-de-Gaume	/fɔ̃ də gom/	fon-duh-GOHM
Les Combarelles	/le kɔ̃.ba.ʁɛl/	lay kom-bah-REL
billetterie (ticket office)	/bi.jɛt.ʁi/	bee-yet-REE
frise des bisons	/fʁiz de bi.zɔ̃/	FREEZ day bee-ZON

Episode 17 — Saint-Émilion, Where the War Ended

Thursday ~12:30, on the A89 west. ~6 min.

SCRIPT

Last full episode, and the trip saves a whole genre for the exit: wine. You're driving out of the Périgord the way the gabarres went — downstream, west, toward Bordeaux — and stopping at Saint-Émilion — pronounced san-tay-mee-LYON — a golden medieval town on a limestone hill that happens to produce some of the most celebrated red wine on earth.

Weddings behind you, one afternoon in hand. The briefing:

Start with the hermit, because the town really is named after one man. Émilion was an eighth-century Breton monk who wanted out of the world and picked a cave in this hillside to want it in. Miracles were reported, disciples gathered, and after his death the community did the most Périgord-adjacent thing imaginable: rather than build a church on the rock, they dug the church out of the rock. Between roughly the ninth and twelfth centuries they hollowed a full monolithic church — one single stone — out of the hill: nave, vaults, windows, all carved downward into living limestone, the largest underground church in Europe, with the bell tower built on top of the hill so it rings above a sanctuary buried beneath the street. You can stand in the square by the bell tower and be standing on the roof of the church. Take the short guided tour if the timing works — it includes the hermit's cave and the catacombs — and if not, the town above ground is compensation enough.

Now the wine, whose star turns out to be the same one as all week: the rock. Saint-Émilion's plateau is limestone — a cousin of the stuff your whole trip is carved from — over clay. For vines this is close to ideal: the roots drive deep, the limestone holds a water reserve and meters it out through dry spells, the clay keeps the vine from ever gorging. Stressed just enough, the vine puts its effort into fewer, more concentrated grapes. Great terroir is mostly well-managed hardship — feel free to steal that for a toast.

Then the grape. This is Merlot country, blended with Cabernet Franc — unlike the Cabernet-led left bank across the river — which makes Saint-Émilion the plusher, rounder, earlier-drinking face of Bordeaux. And Merlot ripens early, which is why your timing matters: mid-September is harvest. Look at the vines as you come in — if crews and crates are out, you're watching the vendange, the one week the whole year points at, and the picking around here is still substantially by hand.

Last, the quarries. The stone to build the town — and half of grand Bordeaux — was mined out from under the vineyards, leaving something like two hundred kilometers of galleries under the appellation. Cool, humid, dead-stable in temperature — you learned why in episode one — those tunnels are now the wine's cellars. The rock that grows the wine also ages the wine; the hill is a machine with no wasted parts.

Two pieces of history to carry in. First: the town has run on ceremony for eight centuries — its wine brotherhood, the Jurade — zhoo-RAHD — descends from the council chartered when this was English Aquitaine — remember, Eleanor’s dowry — and its red-robed members still proclaim the harvest from the top of the King’s Tower each autumn; you’re threading between their festivals. Second, the big one: ten kilometers east of town lies Castillon-la-Bataille, where in July 1453 the French artillery ended the Hundred Years’ War — the war you watched across the ramparts at Beynac on Sunday. Your week began inside that war’s geography and ends at its finish line. When you order a glass this afternoon, you’re drinking at the war memorial; the label just says Grand Cru instead.

Practicals: park outside the walls — the center is pedestrian, steep, and cobbled; the lanes are called tertres — pronounced TAIR-truh — and they are ankle-testers, so it’s the good shoes one last time. Climb or ride up the bell tower area for the view over vineyard rows running to the horizon in September gold. The local sweet is the macaron — not the Parisian sandwich, but the original almond biscuit, baked here to an Ursuline convent recipe since 1620; buy a dozen from one of the old shops, they travel well, and they’re the correct offering to bring home to whoever watered your plants... or to eat in the car. And keep half an eye on the clock: away by three-thirty keeps the whole Bordeaux landing gentle. One tiny episode left — save it for the city limits.

END OF EPISODE 17 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Saint-Émilion	/sɛ̃.t_e.mi.ljɔ̃/	san-tay-mee-LYON
église monolithe	/e.gliz mɔ̃.nɔ̃.liʃ/	ay-GLEEZ mo-no-LEET
Jurade	/ʒy.ʁad/	zhoo-RAHD
vendange	/vɑ̃.dɑ̃ʒ/	vahn-DAHNZH
tertre	/tɛʁtʁ/	TAIR-truh
Castillon-la-Bataille	/kas.ti.jɔ̃ la ba.taj/	kass-tee-YON lah bah-TIE
macaron	/ma.ka.ʁɔ̃/	mah-kah-RON

Episode 18 — Epilogue: Returning the Car at Number Thirteen

Thursday ~16:15, entering Bordeaux. ~2 min.

SCRIPT

Two minutes, mostly practical, then a goodbye.

Practical: refuel near the center before the drop-off — the tank goes back full. And the return office is thirteen Cours Georges Clemenceau — thirteen, not twenty-nine where you picked it up; same street, different door, and that distinction has ruined stronger travelers than you. Aim the navigation at thirteen, hand over the keys, and the driving portion of this program is complete.

Then you're on foot in Bordeaux with an evening in hand, and I have no schedule for you. Maybe the water mirror again at dusk. Maybe just dinner and the long exhale.

Now the goodbye. In six days you two covered a hundred million years of limestone, twenty thousand years of painters, a thousand years of castles, one perfect market, and a wedding. You stood in a copy of the greatest room of the Ice Age, and then in the real dark with real paint, and watched a reindeer lick another reindeer's forehead across fourteen thousand years. What I hope the week leaves with you is this: the valley's whole story is just people finding a good place — warm rock, clean water, food that can be kept, company that can be kept — and refusing to let go of it, for fifty-five thousand years, come ice, war, or fungus. A wedding is the same technology at household scale. The week and the wedding were one subject all along.

Travel home safe, you two. The valley keeps everything — you know that now — so it's keeping your week too, filed somewhere between the Magdalenians and the next lucky couple with a rental car and good shoes.

Merci beaucoup. À la prochaine — ah lah prosh-EN — until next time.

END OF EPISODE 18 SCRIPT

French	IPA	Respelling
Cours Georges Clemenceau	/kʁɔʒ ʒɔʁʒ kle.mɑ̃.so/	KOOR ZHORZH klay-mahn-SOH
à la prochaine	/a la pʁɔ.ʃɛn/	ah lah prosh-EN

The Périgord Tapes · written for two travelers · September 2026 · to be read aloud by a machine and heard on a river road.